

Significant Entries from the Journal of Brother Stephan Dunmorrow
Envoy of Prelate Calvin Van Miserly of St. Ignatius

October 6, 1746

When I first woke today, I was happy to see that my long journey from the Seminary was coming to an end. Across a broad valley, I espied the Hedge, of which I was warned. My good man, Janvermin, sensed some comfort in me, and was quick to dispense with it.

“The Hedge of the Valdenwail” He said grimly, pointing as if I was as nearsighted as my thick spectacles make me seem. “It marks a new phase of our journey. And a phase you shall enjoy as much as the previous”.

The man is cheerful as a gallows keeper. He was right though.

We quickly packed up our austere camp, and headed through the valley and towards the hedge on the other side. This distance I greatly misjudged. It seemed to me a distance of perhaps a half mile. But my judgement was misguided by the size of the Hedge. Thinking it perhaps 20' high, I measured the valley thusly. And so it was that we had to cross a broad valley of *several* miles before our steep ascent up the decrepit road to the edge of that wall of brambles.

The hedge itself must be well over 100' high. Like any natural forest growth, it is thinnest and shortest at the edges. The road, such as it is, is overgrown by the encroaching Hedge at many places, and we were forced to veer off our course several times, and Janvermin had to find our way back. He is good at what he does, though, and we were never waylaid long before he had us marching over top of the ancient stones that form this once-proud road.

After a couple hours of this winding and trail blazing, we came to the densest part of the hedge. By this time, the road was a little better, and as we progressed, the Hedge around us became thicker and more sinister looking; large and wickedly curved thorns decorate the cheerless Hedge trees. One cannot pass anything larger than a hand into the hedge at this point, without sustaining many lacerations.

This thickness and impassability of the hedge is, at this point, marked by its vast height as well. The hedge is certainly over 100' high, but only at some points is it possible to take a sounding of its height, for it is mostly like a tunnel; the grim coppice forming a vaulted tunnel, sometimes just barely over our heads, sometimes many scores of feet above us. Most times, the light of day is so thoroughly obstructed and diffused that one would think it the twilight hour. At some points it is pitch darkness. Still, at times, the canopy opens up, and sunlight falls, and it is much like taking a deep draught of air after a long submersion in a cold and inky lake.

I should say that the path is by no means straight. I doubt very much that we followed one tract of that gloaming grotto that stayed its course for more than 100 yards before an

obtuse change in course presented itself. At many times, the conduit of the Hedge diverged from the ancient stones, only to find the venerable path again after several twists and turns.

Though we did not uncover any forks in the road, we did espy on two separate occasions, something which made us think we were nearing our destination. The first time, to the left of us, we saw some light struggling to penetrate the sable undercroft, and after a protracted bout of straining scrutiny, both I and Janvermin spotted a grey stony structure through the Hedge. We thought we would soon be coming to the Wall that I had been told of, which marks the halfway point of the veiled journey through that joyless furrow. However, the meandrous thoroughfare went soon to the right, and it was long before our next sighting.

Several hours later we again noticed, through and uncommonly thinned, yet still inexplicably obstructive, portion of the Hedge, a length of grey stony wall. This time, we were both able to make out an archway in what was clearly a man-made, though ancient, wall. It was perhaps 50' into the Hedge. I asked my man;

“Perhaps we are meant to carve our way to that bit of stone there, Vermin?”

His look was blank. He looked about briefly, and shrugged his shoulders - an uncommon response from him, to be sure.

“What do you think, man?” I demanded of him.

“I am ashamed to own, Sir,” he replied “I am quite out of my sounding. I have long ago lost track of our direction, and I am no longer even certain of the time of day.”

“Finding the time, at least, takes less skill than a leathery wanderer possesses...” I began. I took my timepiece out of my shirt pocket, and to my horror, I noticed that it had become unwound. It should have been good for a day or two, at least, before it needed winding again. Perhaps this was a coincidence, but I begin to think, now especially, that it was not.

“Well, then!” I commanded myself. “We continue on. Though I have read almost all there is to read of this Hedge and the Valdenwail itself, I have read no tales of forestry efforts or the like. We continue down this crepuscule path!”

Brave words just then. Thinking back on those Hedge-hidden blocks of stone has certainly fueled my imagination. Whatever could those buildings be used for? By whom? How does one arrive at them? How long is it since they have seen the sight of Men?

After those mysterious structures, the path became more serpentine and increased in its opacity for the next several hours, until at last, we were sure that darkness had fallen on the Natural World outside of this confounding Hedge.

We have now made what camp we can. I am thankful, just now, for Janvermin's expertise and circumspection. He had filled all of our skins with fresh water in the nape of the valley before the aperture of the Hedge. I was too excited to tend to such minutiae, but after such a journey, we are both in need of replenishment.

If I never saw pitch blackness before, I have tonight. Our camp is of such a stygian nature, as to make me suspect that cheer and light were but tricks of the mind; falsely remembered and unconceived in fact.

October 7

Today brought more hope with it, but ended with less.

When we both agreed that it must be somewhere around daybreak, we packed up and made our way. We were not convinced of our reckoning for some time; the vault of the Hedge was close in about us for a couple hours (if time exists in such a piceous void as this portion of the Hedge), and we saw no hint of light all that time. Finally, though, the way became more cavernous, and through the brambles above, we again saw light. Such was my joy at the sight of those wan cobbles ahead of us that it was long before I noticed the condition of my guide.

My good man, Janvermin, had been using what little light we had with us (some candles and one anemic lantern which burns more oil than it casts light) to find our way. But he had been using his hands to find our way in some of the more nigrous and sigmoid portions of the journey, and he was covered in wicked lacerations too numerous to tabulate. I implored him to stop so that I could dress his wounds.

Upon cleaning the wounds with what little water we could spare, I noticed that they were grossly inflamed as well. I am no Doctor of Medicine, but I know a dangerous wound when I see one, and he has scores. Already, he has developed a cough and a pallor that worries me.

At any rate, we continued on. The day was full of the same findings as yesterday; the meandering conduit within the Hedge, sometimes following the ancient and worn cobbles, sometimes not, rare sightings of structures, perhaps forgotten by all but us, through this swart nettle.

Finally, though, the road and the path widened, and we followed a straight path up a hill for several hundred yards. The road here, though grown over considerably, revealed some particularly large stones that had engravings of all manners of things upon them. At a few spots along the way, the broken remnants of old statues of many sizes, now covered in the same bracken as the rest of the land, evoked disconsolate images of a great Empire, erstwhile and unremembered. I wanted to examine some of the carvings and statues, but Janvermin would abide none of my distractions. Today, I did not argue with him. He is now a sick man.

That steep approach is bathed in a wan light, as the gorse above is presumably not so thick. Towards the top of the hill, we were able to see quite clearly, a stone wall which obstructed our path, and a great archway in that wall through which we might pass. As before, I misjudged the size of that which I observed. The wall and the archway seemed to get no nearer with my first many steps, until it seemed like we were marching up a most unnatural hill, which checked our progress. But it was long after apparent that the hill was just longer and higher than I thought, as was the wall, and the width of the very road leading to it. Though this misconception is partly due to clever engineering and tricks of scale and perspective, it is also largely due, I am sure, to the unnatural and oppressive nature of the Hedge, and it's adeptness for inspiring confusion and doubt.

At length, we came to the top of the hill, and found ourselves before a great wall and a great archway. I should think that it may have been a veritable splendour of the ingenuity, industry and will of Men, if the wall and the aperture could be seen in the unobstructed light of day. But, though some little light did come through the furze above, it was still no brighter than a cloudy twilight. Details and convolutions upon the wall and the archway there were aplenty. Too many, in fact, to get a focus on one, for the first time observer of this magnificent and cyclopean structure. I should have liked to stay a while and recorded some of them. There is an entire encyclopedia of information and history in that archway, I am sure. But, it was not to be. For starters, my guide would not have permitted a lingering. But it was our new company that hastened things along.

For, we were not alone under that prodigious structure. Under the archway stood a trio of sentinels, as quiet as they were dark. We were both quite frightened when we saw them, and no one stirred a fig for quite some time. I confess that I went through a series of thoughts and emotions. The figures, under that enormous archway, looked like toy soldiers beneath a more commonly sized archway. They provoked fear at first, but then doubt; I thought that perhaps they were statues, so still they stood. But then I *knew* that they were living things, of a stamp. They did not move or make noise or give any other indication to the observer of their prescience, but they did inspire one to realization and further fear.

Finally, after many exchanged glances and whispers between us, Janvermin and I approached the trio of sentinels. That they are of a human proportion and configuration is a good place to begin my description of them. They are adorned with the trappings of men, ancient though they are. There, their likeness to living, breathing men stops.

These sentinels stand about as large as the largest of men. They are clad in bronze armour so old and thick with grime of ages as to appear black in all but the most elevated of reliefs. Their armour is the plate variety that one can now find in museums and the halls of the warlike Saints and Nobles; it covers every possible bit of flesh, and is so bulky and heavy that it was, in its day, more of a liability than an asset, and has thus been replaced by lighter armours in our times. The begrimed armour is covered, on all surfaces, by very intricate relief. I have not had the opportunity, as one could well imagine, to clean and inspect one of these suits properly, but even though the grit of a

dozen centuries chokes those friezes, I could plainly see that the armour *was* beautiful, and that each suit must have a great story to tell.

But that is neither here nor there. The issue at hand was salutations, and those were of the most unusual variety I have ever experienced, and hope never to experience again. I remember a time, during my Investiture at the Seminary, that some of my fellow students would sing the most salacious song. It was entitled *Lonely Sister Rebecca Tuck*, and it was full of all the obvious limericks you might expect from such a title. Anyway, there were verses that would stick in my head for days at a time, and it felt like a veritable intrusion into my own mind. Meeting the sentinels was much the same. That they spoke directly inside my head, I don't doubt, though it was not the same as hearing one speak with a corporeal tongue. I was given the distinct impression by the sentinels that I would not be able to pass without some explanation as to my business in the Valdenwail.

I croaked out an explanation. "Sirs; my apologies for intruding upon your most serene and amicable home. I am Brother Stephan, Envoy from the Seminary of St. Ignatius, and I come bearing a marked letter from His Most Enlightened Prelate Van Miserly, to be delivered to the hands of the Scion of St. Avitus, and none other." I remember looking at my toes the whole time I delivered this speech, and the shiny creases on the folds of the worn leather of my shoes.

I was then aware that I was free to pass, but that Janvermin was not. I stammered a plea for him to accompany me, but it was met with a wall of obstinate will, and I knew that he could not pass. He knew it too.

"I will go down the hill, and await your return" Janvermin said to me through his weak coughs. "I do not wish to wait under the gaze of these things, and under the maw of this wall. I wish you well. Though this place is foreboding, I feel you have safe leave. If they wished you harm, it would have been done to you already. Fare you well, Envoy"

I nodded a weak nod, and approached the sentinels. Finally they moved; they pivoted on one heel, and pointed into the archway, to the gloom beyond. And then, one by one, they turned back to their previous resolute stance.

I journeyed past the sentinels, leaving Janvermin behind. He has been in my mind all the rest of this dreary and trying day. For the Gate is but the halfway point in the Hedge, if what I have read is true, and I have at least 2 days to spend, clawing through this caliginous bramble, before I am delivered from it.

October 12

Today, or rather, tonight, I have emerged from the Hedge, not 2 days, but several, since the Gate. I scarcely noticed that I had emerged, as it is a moonless and overcast night, and light is but a memory to me again. I have a few scratches from the Hedge, and my mind is on fire half the time, and dreamy the other half. Now, with a hint of breeze in my hair, I again feel like I have command of my senses, though I have not these past several

days. I feel like I have just woken up from a very long bout of sleep walking through a nightmare.

October 13

It is first thing in the morning, and though it is raining and dismal, the grey sky has a hint of lithium where the sun is hidden, and I know that I am free of the Hedge. Before me is a rolling moor, with a lonely road of ancient cobblestones tracking a path through the downcast countryside. The moor is very boggy at this point, but there are some patches of bright green growth at the peaks of some small hills, and their colour is the only hope I have seen in this entire Ecclesiarchy. The wind is strong, but refreshing. It has the smell of the ocean that I was told to expect, though I had never smelled myself.

Later on...

I spent all day in my solitary travel down the old road, and have seen not a soul. The road is broad, and many of the stones, like some of those before the Gate, have been carved with friezes and words. The language is clearly Old Imperial, though much of it is interspersed with older characters that I cannot discern. I have made drawings of some of them, but the weather is too foul for such business, and I must make haste.

Tonight, I make my lonesome camp under a large rock on top of a hill. I found a little stream, and have filled my flasks and drunk, and feel coherent and well for the first time in days.

Though I feel well, I wonder how poor Janvermin is faring. Already, I am far behind schedule. We estimated 2 more days in the hedge, 2 days to the Valdenwail, a day there, and 4 back to the Gate. I have been 5 days emerging from that damnable Hedge. I hope that Janvermin has both patience and health to hold.

October 14

Today has been drizzly all day. The soggy skies seem satisfied to deliver as little moisture as possible, to protract its irrigous business as long as possible. The wind blows right into my face as I continue in what I now think is a south-easterly direction. It has been increasing its fierceness all day, and the organic smell of the ocean is growing stronger.

I saw people for the first time today. They were very distant, perhaps the better part of a mile away, and several hills removed from the road. They seemed to have a small flock of sheep or some other animal with them. We looked at each other for a long time across a hilly lowland, and at length I decided to approach them. I was not certain what I would have to say to a bunch of rustic shepherds (in any part of the world, let alone this bygone country), but I was in need of *any* human interaction. I think I would have settled for a beating from them, if they would have it.

They wouldn't. By the time I got to their previously espied location, they were gone. I must confess that I doubted my sanity at that point. I worried that I was imagining people, and shepherds at that! But no; I have spent enough time on the road with Janvermin to know to look at it once in a while, and sure enough, there were plenty of tracks of both men and beasts, and I was satisfied that I was not insane, but rather unsavoury company for these folks, and set back to my trail.

October 15

I am camped at the gates of the Valdenwail, and won't be admitted tonight. Such execrable hospitality I have never encountered, in even the most anonymous of bywaters.

The day began with a continuation of the doleful weather for which I have now come to associate with this dispiriting Ecclesiarchy. A deliberate march through the rolling hills brought me alternatively from the boggy swales, to the wind-blasted heaths of this woebegone moor. As the march progressed, I became aware that I was climbing higher and higher, and the nadirs of the rolling moor became tolerably moist the further I went, though the bitter wind became fiercer upon those unwelcoming zeniths.

I should say a thing about the road at this point. The road follows a very irregular course, and there are at many points, ancient junctions that lead to Sodor's Door for all I know. It is only by the lasting and antediluvian virtue of the map which I copied from the *Magnus Corpus Avitus* that I was able to make my way to my final destination. The road is confounding, to be sure, though, and I had to 'back track' (as Janvermin would call it) many times. The road leading to the Valdenwail itself is unmistakable though; all of the secondary arteries which I found myself walking down soon proved to be of an even more senescent and disused nature, if a magnitude of age and neglect greater than that of the primary thoroughfare can be imagined. I confess that it makes my head swim to think of such ancient roads, once so large and well constructed, becoming so old and timeworn as to be all but forgotten. What once happened upon those quondam arteries of Empire?

One veritably stumbles into the Valdenwail, if it can be imagined. In the last league before the ancient acropolis, the approach becomes very difficult. The land becomes very stony and mountainous, with very little vegetation of any variety beyond nasty fungi, and the road at this portion of the journey has been carved out of the rock itself; it is much like a trough in the stone, and at many points, crumbling bulwarks rise above the edge of the trough, and stare down menacingly, like an old man with no teeth, at the weary traveler on that compromised road. This rocky flume has certainly been carved out of the now-mountainous country for a dual purpose; it allows some semblance of ease of navigation through what would now otherwise require the aide of a seasoned mountaineer, but it also provides a quite compromised position for any invader that might come up this road. Certainly, the *MCA* makes reference to the 'Upper Channel', which is inaccessible to those on the 'Lower Channel', though the lower traveler is at the mercy of those upon the Upper.

At one junction in the Lower Channel, I did take my time to do some drawings. Here, the channel is some 100' wide, and relatively flat and smooth. The walls to either side are carved straight up out of the mountain, and rise some 80-100', so that I find myself standing in a magnificent concourse of illuminated stone, for the walls here are covered in friezes too numerous to count, and many as beautiful as the day they were chiseled from that unforgiving stone. Here, the elements are held at bay, somewhat, by a great precipice which rises hundreds of feet above the trough in its natural jagged fashion, and the salty winds blowing off the ocean have not smoothed the rock here as they have in many other parts of this journey. The flagstones themselves are a rich tapestry of history, and the walls are lined with statues of men and women and creatures that are forgotten by all save the most privileged and lore-stepped inhabitants of the Valdenwail.

The Channel at this point comes to an intersection; a secondary (by virtue of being smaller and heading back downhill at an obtuse angle) artery runs off the main course, so that the road here is somewhat 'Y' shaped. To the left, the road runs under a great arch which is suspended about 100' above the descending road. The arch is fantastic itself; for starters, it is nearly anachronistic in its architectural quality. I would not have suspected such delicate and lasting arches from the primeval architects and builders of this ancient place. The arch forms a covered bridge, of a type; a stony rampart of many levels and convolutions spans this 100' wide gap upon the arch, and this structure alone would be heralded as a great castle in any lands I have been, Waldheim included. When I got there, it was nearly eventide, though, and not one black window framed a hint of light. The sight of such a magnificent structure, so cleverly conceived, artfully constructed, graceful to behold, and seemingly impregnable, the sight of it in such a state of neglect and disuse made me so saturn that I nearly wept.

However, I knew that I was getting closer. The towers and battlements that rise above the carved-out trough became more frequent (though in no greater condition of repair or use) and much more impressive. The journey became much steeper as I went along as well, and I had to scramble over some debris at many points, presumably from depreciating battlements above me; by this time, it was quite dark and the rain had become quite fierce. A great howling was overhead as well, and occasionally a thunderous whistling (one really must hear it to agree that this description, while seemingly oxymoronic, is actually accurate) came down the Channel accompanied by stinging blasts of the salty, acrimonious gale.

Finally, though, at the peak of a steep climb, I found myself under another great archway, this one like a great two-pronged fork, with great towers rising well over 100' above the archway which is suspended across the 80' deep Channel. Steep bluffs rise to either side of the archway and the towers, and I could vaguely make out the dark arches of what must be the Upper Channel, where it runs as a tunnel through one rocky bluff, across a small arch to one tower, across the greater arch, through the other tower, across another small arch, and into another dark tunnel in the opposite bluff. But it was not this detail of the ancient architecture which caught my focus, for before me is the Valdenwail.

The ascent to this peak is so high and steep that you cannot have any notion that such an amazing acropolis is just on the other side, waiting to surprise you like a bandit hiding behind a great fallen log. As you climb this last bit of this unhappy road, you are compelled to take in the twin towers, which I believe are named *Gromhaufel* and *Zuirenhahst*, so that the vista beyond the zenith is sprung like a trap. Add to this contrivance of the clever and ancient architects, the merciless winds which come straight off the ocean and up to this peak, racing for your exposed and tender flesh like coursing hounds for the hare, which force you to recoil and make your redoubt before you can again look out, and you find yourself at a loss of initiative, to be sure.

When I did finally recover from the elements, having bundled up tight and shrinking my head into my shoulders as well as I may, I looked out, and was robbed of breath. The Valdwail was right there, not 200 yards down a gently sloping section of the trough, and it terminated the trough as sure as a spade through a snake. I shall try to describe what can be seen of the Valdwail from this vantage;

To begin, this portion of the rocky land becomes more gentle; it is less than a mile from beneath the arch of the two towers to the cliff that drops off to the Sea which forms the Valdwail's most resolute southern boundary, and this expanse is mostly a benign plateau, for the most part free of the rugged mountains through which the traveler has just emerged. From the archway, there is a gentle slope downwards towards the Valdwail which broadens from its span of about 100' under the arch, to perhaps a mile at the foot of the bulwark of the Valdwail. On either side of this gentle descent, the rocky eminence rises nearly straight up like a jagged wall. The plateau upon which the Valdwail has stood for so many centuries is perhaps 7 miles from east to west, and the thickest parts of the sprawling and ancient acropolis might be as wide as 1 and one half miles from the southern cliff to the northern mountain which makes its borders. In the middle, which is roughly where I find myself now, the Valdwail is at its thinnest, being only perhaps 200 yards from bulwark and gate to the southern cliff, so that the unimaginably large place has the shape, roughly, of a kidney bean with a very narrow middle.

The plateau is also very lunate, curving away sharply from the narrow middle, so that I can see the face of the steep cliff and the great walls that sit upon it at the eastern- and western-most reaches, and how those walls have the seeming of something that has grown from the rock, rather than having been hewn from it, or stacked upon it, so long have they cohabitated together. Now that I think of it, if one was to imagine the seagull's view of this place (though there are fewer of those than one would expect to find around a seaside castle of any size, let alone this one) I suppose it would look much like a gentleman's bow-tie in shape.

The Valdwail rises slightly towards its eastern and western extremities, and at its edges it has crept up the sides of the steep rock that borders the plateau, so that thousands of empty windows and archways, and hundreds of balconies and small towers, decorate the lower reaches of those impassable bluffs which frame the plateau. The Valdwail chokes every square inch of the plateau, save for the open approach from the two towers

to the main Gates below. The approach, here as with much of the Lower Channel, is bordered by the steep walls that have been hewn out of the stone, upon which the bulwarks and small towers of the Upper Channel sit, abandoned, watching with sightless eyes for erstwhile enemies.

After crossing about 200 yards down the yawning approach to the illimitable fortress-city, I find myself at the Gates of the Valdenwail. At this point, the great wall rises up before me, and stretches in its incongruous and convoluted manner, from one precipice to the other. At its lowest point, the wall must be 60' or perhaps less, but well over 200' in some of the highest portions of this mile and a half long battlement. There are towers every 100' or so, and they are of a great variety of styles, shapes and sizes. One thing is consistent in the architecture of what I have seen of the Valdenwail so far, though; the ubiquitous greenish-grey stone from which it has been built. I have no doubt that this stone that has been quarried from the vast trench which runs for such a great distance approaching the acropolis; the walls of the Lower Channel are of this same sickly hue.

At the centre of the great wall is the unmistakable Portis Primus of the acropolis. A great tower over 200' in height, and covered in smaller balconies and towers like an ancient tree covered with countless hoary burls and clinging lunate fungi, dominates the centre of the wall. At its base, an archway stands like a great letter 'm', with a pillar the size of which I have never encountered elsewhere, supporting the middle. The double-archway is over 100' high, and to each side of the pillar, a 25' wide opening marks the entrance to the Valdenwail. That this tower is old beyond reckoning is doubtless. The stone is covered in a thick and shaggy green moss higher than the apex of the double arch, and above that, it is so worn from centuries of this merciless weather as to be polished to a shine.

I should say at this point that images in my mind of an Empire of great vastness and power did come flooding in. How much effort does it take to create such a structure as this, so prodigious and ornate? How many thousands of lives of men were spent to build this peerless expanse of towers and arches and battlements and countless and untold things unseen? As I approached the Gates, I had visions of thousands of men going through those Gates, hauling huge blocks of stone, as large as a small house in, while thousands poured out to gather more. I had visions, too, of vast armies of mounted men, with great siege machines rolling ponderously behind, coming out of those proud Gates like sunlight through the clouds. But when I got close enough in this gloom to fetch a better look at them, my visions were sundered. Though the Gate Tower is certainly ancient, counting its years by millennia, it has been modified relatively recently. It is important to say 'relatively', for the newer stones of which I speak were certainly laid hundreds of years ago, likely about 400 years ago, if I am any student of History. The huge double aperture of the Gate Tower has been sealed almost entirely shut; large stone blocks have obstructed those twin maws, like so many bricked-over windows to be found in Waldheim. However, at the base of the easterly opening, a large wooden door stands in a new archway, some 8' wide and 12' tall; large enough for any activities that this castle now sees in its denouement.

There are three Armoured Guardians, nearly identical to those found at the Hedge Gate, standing in the great Tower Gate double arch which I have just described, and these three made the same supernatural contact with me as I approached. They seemed to expect me, and I sensed that I could approach the door. As I approached, one turned its armoured head to take me in. I could see no flesh beyond the slight opening of his full helmet, and though I could see my breath come as excited puffs of fog on this cold maritime eve, none issued forth from their helms.

The centre of the large door is adorned with a cast-iron ring about the size of a well tile, and it was only with great effort that I was able to swing it precariously back, and then strike the door with a resounding 'thud'. The castle is so large that I couldn't imagine that a doorman would be by any time soon, and, indeed, the sentinels seemed to suggest to me by way of their disquieting mental impressions, that I would have to wait for some time, and not strike the door again.

The next couple of hours were the worst I ever spent. I feared to stay too close to the door and the Sentinels, but feared to stray too far from it as well. When I became anxious, at times, and contemplated striking the door again, I was met with those same walls of resolute will that told me 'wait, and do not strike that door again'. So I waited, and paced, and tried to stay out of the gaze of the sentinels and in sight of the door all at once, which is a geographical impossibility and a great source of anxiety for me.

But, at last, the door opened. Or rather, a small aperture, heretofore unnoticed by this envoy, opened up in the door; it was a smaller door about 2' x 2', and I was immediately warned of it's opening by the pale flickering light that issued forth from it. I was startled, but gathered myself quickly, and stepped up as professionally as I am known to do, and began into my usual salutations, which were cut short before I had one syllable formed, by a very inelegant and loutish greeting from an unseen mouth;

"It is late! The Valdenwail will have no visitors this time of night!" and with that, the little door slammed shut.

Though the sentinels moved not an inch after this, I could feel their great Wills pressing down upon me, and knew that I could not press the issue further. I made a hasty and downcast retreat back up the gentle slope of the approach, and over the tempest-swept crest beneath the two towers, where I now write from.

I have a miserable camp tonight; everything I have is soaked thoroughly, and I don't think I have been more crestfallen in my entire life. It has been a challenging journey to get here, and though the sight of this matchless fasthold was uplifting beyond my expectations, it has made my disappointment all the more difficult to bear. And just now, I have thought of poor Janvermin, who is doubtless ill beyond bearing, and full of questions about my whereabouts. I am long overdue.

But, there is one thing that makes it bearable. Just after setting up my simple camp, I journeyed to the crest again, and took another long look at that sprawling bastion, and

though there are ten thousand black windows looking back at me, there are 4 yellow ones, and a little trail of smoke from a fire somewhere deep within the bowels of that impossibly huge acropolis.

October 16

I spent a horrible night, and will spend another likewise. Owing partly to my excitement at finally reaching the legendary Valdenwail, partly to my aches from a perilous journey, and partly from my limitless discomfort in what little shelter I could find from the tempest which raged on through the night, I slept not a wink. Shortly before sunrise, the rage of the elements withered to a dull and monotonous thudding of heavy rain, and little wind. Though I was soaked through and shivering from head to toe, I packed up, and perched myself at the crest beneath the arch of the two towers, and watched the Gates of the Valdenwail with an absent determination. I crouched like an animal, propped half against one wall of the trough, and moved not an inch for countless hours (my watch is still not working, and is now so hopelessly waterlogged that it will need the benefit of a visit to the watchmaker in Waldheim before it will keep time again). Though I moved not a bit of my frame, my eyes moved constantly from looking south at the Gates, to the east where I expected the sun to rise.

Eventually, what passes for a sunrise in this dismal Ecclesiarchy did perchance to present itself. It was a long and drawn out affair, and agonizing for the expectant viewer. I supposed that the sun would bring some warmth to my bones, and open the Gates for me, and so I watched expectantly, waiting anxiously for those warming rays. They never came. A pale grey light formed in the east, and it has not brightened all day. The clouds rolled slowly across the skies, from east to west, and though the sun did creep up over the mountains, it has not burnt its way through those obstructing clouds, and has delivered little light and no warmth to this land. I think these stones would abhor a condition of warmth and sun.

At any rate, when the sun was at a position in the sky behind the clouds that I took to indicate 8 bells, I again made my approach to the double arch of the Gates. The same three sentinels were still there in the same spot I left them last night, the time and rain seeming to have no affect upon their unflinching disposition. I was sure that I was going to receive nothing better than a scurrilous greeting from the brusque and unseen doorman from the night before, but I received less than that. As I approached, I could feel the weight of the Will of those sentinels upon me, and I knew that it was not yet time to ring the oversized knocker. I slowed my approach, and turned back.

For several hours, I tread the path from the crest beneath the two towers, to the Gates of the Valdenwail, and upon each approach, I was repelled by the will of the Sentinels. I watched that pale obstructed glow arc slowly up, and then quickly down. Long after the faded lithium of the concealed sun was past its zenith, and fast approaching the peaks of the mountains to the west, I steeled myself, and approached the relatively diminutive wooden door of the Gates. This time, too, the Will of the sentinels bore down upon me, but I was determined to do my job, and though I struggled with my own fears and their

unspoken threats, I did finally reach that enormous knocker, and my cold-numbed hands managed to rock it back a few inches, which was enough for it to resound as clearly as it had last night. Upon the report from this ludicrous implement of greeting, all three of the sentinels turned slightly to face me, and their Wills pressing down upon me were like a black avalanche. But, I stayed my position, and defiantly faced the small portal in the door beneath the knocker from which I expected my unfriendly greeting.

After about an hour of standing there, shifting my weight and courage uncomfortably, the small portal in the door did open suddenly. It is only at about chest height, and I had to bend down to look into it to face my greeter. My greeter was doing likewise, and was clearly unhappy to be doing so. There was an old face on the other side of the door, and it showed perhaps 50 years, perhaps 100, it was difficult to tell. It was not likely a pretty face in its youth either; only one yellow eye looked at me, while the other jaundiced orb wandered randomly like a dog in a park, whilst our short salutations were done. We sized each other up, and he snorted in contempt at the sight of me, and barked out his greeting;

“No visitors to the Valdenwail on the Feast of St. Oledan!” and with that the small door slammed shut on my face.

I felt dejected but not surprised. The three sentinels, sensing my defeated will, turned back to their original positions after their hour-long scrutiny of me, and though there was no physical evidence, and little supernatural impression, I could not but help feeling as though they wore smug smiles on whatever faces might be found beneath those flesh-eclipsing helms. I made my way back to my previous night’s camp, on the other side of the crest beneath the arch and two towers. It is here that I am sure I will die a slow death of exposure and tergiversation. “Feast of St. Oledan” indeed! I have never heard of such a Saint, and though I should be more modest, I am quite accomplished in my studies of the Saints at the Seminary. But then, here I am, camped out at the seat of the Saintly Faith in Avitus, where more knowledge has been hidden over the ages than can ever be guessed at. Who am I to doubt the existence of a Saint Oledan, or the veneration of this obscure Saint within the walls of the Valdenwail.

There is but one thing that disquiets me; before tonight, I could name 158 Saints and the dates of most of their veneration and ceremonies. Now, I can name 159, and though by the Grace of St. Ignatius, I wish to learn all I can of matters Saintly and otherwise, I hope that the callow concierge of the Valdenwail teaches me no more before I am lead to a fire and a bowl of warm food under a dry roof.

Already, my hand is too shaky to continue this book of days. I shall not write again before I am lead to warmth.

What of Janvermin?

October 20?

I must begin by bridging the gap in this chronicle. I spent four nights at least camped outside the Valdenwail, and they were all spent in misery. It may have been five nights, but I was so consumed by hunger and cold that I may have spent another unknown. I was wet and cold almost the entire time, until I resolved to go back to the sheltered intersection that I spoke of on the 15th. I knew the elements would not be as terrible there, and I was able to spend one night in comfort, and get some of my things dry. I did not want for water (in fact, I was in want of drought long before the door of the Valdenwail was opened to me), but I ran out of food on the 18th, and as I write tonight, I have a terrible rumble in my bowels from having eaten a terrible meal in too-few bites after too long a fast.

This morning, the 20th as best as I can tell, I was finally admitted to the Valdenwail. I was quite delirious and weak by the time the door was opened to me, and there are few details I can remember from that encounter. I do know the name of the man who has let me in though, as I have spent much of the day with him, and him only. If there is another soul living in the Valdenwail, I have no evidence of it.

Numble Evanshore is his name, and he calls himself by so many titles, from Door Warden to Executor, that certainly he must have a very long list of duties within the walls of this lorn acropolis. The man looks to be quite old, and in terrible health. With the exception of making quick and curt disallowances, he does nothing fast. He creaks and rattles along on knees that make more noise than rusty chains being dragged over a cobbled street, and the sound of his breathing reflects the moistness of the environment in which this place exists; surely his lungs are three parts full of fluid and poison and sickness, so that each breath is a struggle for the decrepit and pitiable thing, and the wheezing that follows each shrinking of his exsanguinous chest leaves a lump in my throat.

I was admitted to the place, and followed Numble through a dream. I would like to say that I mastered my discomforts, and took in the splendour of the fabled Valdenwail, but I did not. My first several hours within those hallowed walls were spent in a delirious stupour; my whole body had been soaked and chilled to the core, and indeed, to my brain, and I had no wit or senses beyond an instinct to follow Numble where ever he might be taking me. I am not sure how many hours we marched through that boundless labyrinth of superannuated stone, but at last, he brought me to the place I now write from.

I am now a resident of Dunvegan House. When I first arrived on the broad porch of this place, I had regained some little strength and warmth from my long walk through the acropolis. I noticed Numble struggling with a huge ring of keys of many different varieties, and he was saying to himself "Not an easy job, these days, being Key Deacon" and he let out such a lung-rumble that I thought he might die that instant. Where would I be then?

Anyway, he opened the door, and hobbled in, and made an irritated gesture for me to follow him. I did. He lit a single candle in the modest foyer, and spoke again.

“Dunvegan House. You will be our guest here and here only. There is logs and food in here.”

I began to muster myself for a delivery of my formal request to deliver my letter to the Scion, but Numble guessed I had something to say, and cut me off by waving both his hands at me in a feeble and tired dismissive gesture. “Save yer breath for billowing your fire, messenger. And don’t leave Dunvegan House”. He left, and he locked the door from the outside after he did. I am now a prisoner in the Valdenwail.

However, it is not a terrible incarceration. Though, perhaps I am just happy of any place that will shelter me from the relentless rains and wind that assault the Lower Channel and any luckless traveler thereupon.

After Numble left, I took the candle, and wandered through the dusty place, and found many more candles to light. I was so thankful of the small warmth and light that I lit every candle that I found, and those were thankfully many. This is a reasonably large place, though I am sure it has seen no guests in decades. The dust is thick upon every surface, and most of the furniture has been covered, though those coverings are now so moth eaten and threadbare that promontories on every piece can be seen peeking through the sheets.

My time on the road with Janvermin has again proven useful. After walking around the house searching for more candles to light, I noticed a track in the dust heading into a chambre that I had not yet been to. I cautiously entered the room, a lighted candle held aloft as my only weapon. The room was a kitchen, and it was empty of all life save mine. I followed the tracks to a large oak table, and thereupon I found a small sack of food and a bundle of sticks and one small log for a fire.

I am ashamed to own that I conducted myself like a beggar who has found a shilling, at that point. Upon discovering the food in the bag, I began to consume it in a most beastly manner, and it was this lapse in manners that earned me the gastric discomfort that I now own. At first glance, it seemed a rustic, though hearty meal; a couple of apples, a small wheel of cheese, some bread and a piece of thick dark meat. I ate the bread first, and had it all in my gullet before I noticed the dull acidic taste of mold in the back of my throat. It was strong enough to put me into a bout of coughing that might have rivaled Numble’s knells.

With no more dining caution than I practiced with the bread, I attacked the meat, tearing a mouthful from it and swallowing it down with little mastication. It stuck, and I paused. In this short pause, I took a moment to smell the morsel in my hand, and found it to be a very sub-comestible slab of foulness; it smelled like a leper’s foot, and was waxy as a corpse. I tried to hack up the piece stuck in the back of my throat, but somehow managed to swallow it down completely during my masticatory convulsions. It now rots in my

stomach, but it must have some virtue in it, for though I feel trembles in my depths, at least I have some feeling.

A quick examination of the apples found them waxy and soft, and the cheese...I shall not think on it further. There was one bottle of red wine though, and that, I confess, is the finest I have ever had. Perhaps they have put some sweet poison in it.

Because the sticks and log were in the kitchen, I decided to start a fire in the cooking hearth in this room, rather than bother with carrying them to a more comfortable chambre. This laziness is deplorable in a graduate of the Seminary of Saint Ignatius, but I feel that my constitution has been tried beyond reason, and this one lapse in effort should be excused. At any rate, it cost me more energy in the end; I found a very comfortable burgundy leather chair in a drawing room, and decided on dragging it into the kitchen to enjoy the warmth of the small fire. The chair was certainly heavier than the wood. But it could be that I have made the right decision. The kitchen is small, and it is now quite warm.

I am now nodding off, and this leather chair will be a fine bed.

Just now, though, I have thought again of Janvermin. My rest will not be too sound.

October 21?

I have seen no one today, but have had a reasonably eventful day despite my lonesome incarceration.

I awoke at...time is now lost completely to me. I am not sure of the time of day, nor the day itself. No sunlight penetrates this Archeronian Acropolis. I have explored Dunvegan House thoroughly, and have found all the windows one might expect in an Urban home of a well-to-do burgher, but there is no light beyond them. I thought that perhaps I had awoken at night, but at least a dozen hours have passed, and there is still no hint of light. I believe that even the streets of this place are completely covered over, and no light is permitted into the Valdenwail even upon the thoroughfares. There were rumours, heretical and controversial in the most severe nature, that one Scion in ages past was some form of Vampire, and had the entire place roofed over during a reign of hundreds of years. Though I cannot speak for the sanguinous character of the present Scion or any past, the streets are certainly covered, so that the Valdenwail is submerged in perpetual night.

Dunvegan House is four stories high, and was once well appointed. There are a score of bedrooms, numerous small turrets, two large entertaining rooms, one with an illuminated marble floor, a small theatre, several dining rooms, several kitchens, and numerous rooms besides. Though all the rooms were full of decorations and furnishings of a bygone opulence, covered and dusty though they were, it was the one room that had been robbed of its trappings that caught my attention, and provided a distraction from this protracted and trying service; the library. The library of Dunvegan House is a 2-story affair, and

might have held ten thousand books in its day. There are great expanses of wall with nothing to adorn them, and as these are the only glabrous walls in the House, I am led to believe that they once displayed maps. The multitudinous bookshelves were all but bare. I began to wonder if the *Repurgo Imperialis* managed to find its way into these walls as well. There is really no indication in any History I have studied to suggest one thing or the other. Perhaps it did. Or perhaps my graceful and courteous hosts have removed any information from this place that they think might offend the sensibilities of their unenlightened guests.

At any rate, they did not remove everything. I did find one book in a dark corner shelf, and this discovery urged me to further exploring. After hours of filling the library with candles, and then poking candles into every dark shadow that remained, I found a very incongruous collection of a score of books. There is not one book in that collection newer than 500 years old, and this find would be classed as monumental in any part of Avilund. The books all display some evidence of their venerable age, but are well preserved for the most part. Given the amount of rain this country seems to experience, I was surprised to find only a little bit of black and green mold in some of the books. Certainly, this is a well constructed building, to admit none of the rain that assaults it so. In fact, whilst searching the library, I could hear the rain thrumming the roof high above, as the ceiling of the library must be the roof of the House.

The books are all written in Old Imperial, as one could well imagine. Again, however, they are interspersed with much language that is unknown to me, and several are in fact entirely obscure to me, being written in a language that not only can I not read, but cannot determine the language or even the alphabet base. Perhaps they are written in the apocryphal *Angelic* or *Devilish* or *Demonic*. I do not know. I have made copies of many of the characters and words, including the titles of the books herein.

I have now spent countless hours pouring through these books, and I do not know where to begin describing what I have found. I shall save it for later. Though I have had a physically undemanding day, I am still weak from my journey and exposure, and still suffer a phlegmatism that would have many patients bed ridden. I am hungry, but earlier found another canvas sack of the same shoddy provisions that I encountered yesterday. The apples alone I ate, and the wine, again, was fantastic. It alone sustains me.

October 25?

I can now name 162 Saints. I have endured the Consumption of St. Belarus, The Immolation of St. Donovan, and the Crucifixion of St. William. As one could well imagine, the Scion will not admit company on these most obscure, but surely, most holy of days.

I have been able to catch Numble most days. After my discovery in the library, and the subsequent discovery of my replenished, though spare, provisions and wood, I realized that Numble had every intention of sneaking in, day by day, and supplying me without the courtesy of salutations, let alone consideration for the furtherance of my appointed

task. So, the next day, I sat in the kitchen where he left the previous provisions and wood. On this occasion, he brought his bundle only as far as the foyer.

The next day, I camped out in the foyer, and in a dark corner at that. Sure enough, he came sneaking in through the door after his long and noisy fumbling of keys.

“Good day, Numble!” I said, as I came springing out of my hiding. I quite surprised Mr. Numble, and he started into a bout of coughing that sounded something like boots prodding through a thick and sludgy bog. His knees knocked and creaked all the time, so that he produced a veritable cacophony of phlegmatic and rattling noises that I am sure rang through all the obsidian-black streets of this sunless acropolis. I smiled, probably for the first time in days.

“Or rather” I continued “Good night, or whatever time of day it is in this perdurable pitch!” By this time I had crossed the small foyer to the man, who was still in the middle of his violent, barking throes, and was unable to take my proffered hand, or to make any other gestures of greeting for that matter. It mattered not to me at this time, proper manners and conduct being all distant memories to me now.

“I see you are quite unwell today, my good man. I hope you will recover, and bring me to see the Scion before you expire, good sir!” I continued, through his hacking and gurgling and rattling and shaking. I folded my arms behind my back, smiled, and rocked back and forth on my heels, watching to see if the octogenarian would die or not. He did not.

He began by waving one finger at me in a very dismissive manner. He was nearly doubled over at this time, one hand on one knee, keeping him from falling over altogether. He cranked back his clicking, skeletal neck, and brought up his bony face over one shoulder to shoot a long, contemptuous look at me. Clearing his throat, he said “Yew! not go a step past this threshold on the Consumption of St. Belarus, you Saintless beggar!” He gave the sack of food and the small pile of sticks that he had dropped a languorous kick, and turned to leave.

“Good Sir!” I ejaculated. “Please! My apologies for an ungraceful salute, Sir. I wish only to carry out my duties, and to rid myself of your charge and dutiful care.” Yes, I had quite changed my posture and position. I now felt bad, mostly because the man who I had so satisfyingly surprised held my fate in my hands, but seeing the man kick at the pile of sticks so weakly made me pity him again.

He clucked his tongue, by way of answering me, and made his leave, locking me in again.

For the next couple of days it was the same, though he expected me, and gave me new observances to learn before quitting my company and locking me in. Tonight, or whenever, I decided that I would make my leave of this place, and look around a bit. For the first time in all my days, I am quite finished reading, having taken in all the words I

know of the various books that I have found here. I confess that I know that I should make the best of my time incarcerated here, and make a complete study of these antiquated tomes, but I am now weary of Dunvegan House, and its unflagging dust and cobwebs. I have found a total of sixty eight windows in this great house, and sixty seven of them are nailed shut. The last is on the second floor, and it looks out from a small bedroom in which there are enough sheets that have escaped the moths, and I have made a rope of them, and plan to descend.

October 26-27?

I have been exploring, and nearly forfeited my life for it. I will not be exploring again, as I have gained one doorman, of a stamp, to keep an unsleeping eye upon me.

After I had slept, and woke at a nebulous time, I mustered my courage to go exploring in the Valdenwail. I packed up my back pack with what little food I have been able to keep, several candles, and one bottle of the excellent wine of this place (I have had a couple of bottles come my way with antediluvian labels upon them which read "Valdenholme Vinyard" with dates varying from 888 to 1207, though surely they did not contain the original contents).

I pried open the second floor window, and made the rope fast to the large bed, and made my descent. Again, I met stygian blackness on the street below, but I could tell by the feel beneath my feet that I was upon ancient and undisturbed cobbles. I had one candle alight, and it cast enough light for me to follow one wall on my right, though I could not see anything to my left, nor a roof above me. Clearly, though, the street had but a single layer of roof above; I could clearly hear the rain sounding off above me. It made a sound that hinted to me that the roof might be covered with slates.

I followed the grey stone wall on the right for quite some time. The wall is made of enormous blocks, the smallest of which having no less than four square feet of face. Though there is some mold at the base of it, there is almost no other vegetation besides. The streets are a little dusty, though for the most part free of debris. I should add that the smell of the place was not as musty as I would have expected, but rather, like dry earth after a long drought.

For several hundred paces did I follow that grey monolithic Dunvegan House to my right. At a few points in the journey, I happened upon great stone pillars that came upon me like ghosts, from the darkness to my left, as I wandered cautiously along. They were all meticulously cut from blocks six feet exactly on all sides, and stacked higher than my candle would illuminate (I could see the bottom half of the fourth block). These blocks, though precisely carved and placed, lack the illuminated friezes that adorn much of the older masonry I have encountered in the Valdenwail, which makes me think that they are much newer additions to the place. Perhaps these are the columns which support the newer thoroughfare-ceilings of which I was told. I cannot see to the top of them, so I cannot say for sure.

Now, it is foolish to go about exploring in just about any place without some way to keep track of where you have been, and the Valdenwail is perhaps the worst place of all for such a journey. But as I have said, I have found scores of candles in Dunvegan House, and I have borrowed them for the purpose of finding my way back. At each intersection that I came to, I lit a new candle and left it burning there. Of course, I have lit the largest candles first, and I knew that I had about 6 hours, no more, to spend at large in the Valdenwail.

I was unable to follow a straight course through that dateless darkness for more than a few hundred paces, so labyrinthine is the Valdenwail. The place is very much a covered city. Though I walk on what are certainly streets, every avenue is covered entirely by the slate roof, supported by the huge pillars.

The streets are of ancient cobbles, and there are elevated walking stones to the sides of the streets for those afoot, while horses and conveyances would be able to rumble past at any speed down the middle. Very few streets in Waldheim are constructed such, but here, even the smallest of alleys down which I have lost myself, I found this same sound and considerate construction. There are portcullised holes in the streets that most certainly lead to a sewer network of some variety. It makes my head swim to think of the darkness-under-darkness of a sewer-realm which may exist beneath this enduring blackness. It is a further marvel to me that this most antiquated acropolis would have a peerless infrastructure to match its peerless prodigious volume. But, if I were to imagine this place full of the teeming peoples it could certainly accommodate, I should not be surprised that the architects of this place have included such details.

For the most part, what I have seen of the Valdenwail is a multitude of large row-houses, at least 3 stories tall, perhaps much taller in places (I can use the sound of the rain above to roughly estimate heights). They are sound, and most are covered in elegant details and convoluted friezes. They are each a marvel, and any one of them would be the pride of any street in Waldheim, but here, where stunning, enduring beauty is the status quo, they are legion.

As I passed the doors of the larger buildings, some would remind me of the door to Dunvegan House, and I got to thinking, "How many other messengers are entombed behind those taciturn doors, their charge failed, their bones and undelivered messages now so much dust upon the lonely floor?" This descended me into a melancholy. The thought of dying of protracted incarceration in the Valdenwail is too much to bear. The situation is all the more woeful, as this is a prison of matchless historical significance, and under any other circumstances, I, a Distinguished Graduate of the Seminary of St. Ignatius, should think I would have loved to retire to such a place and spend all my days studying the limitless statuary, friezes, frescoes, tapestries, and other objects too numerous in variety and quantity to name herein, until I pass. Surely, this is the Antiquarian's Dream, to be trapped in the very Heart of the Empire of Men, with nothing but time and wits. And here I am, spending my time wandering aimlessly, taking in the atramentous spectacle like a byway farmer wandering the streets of Waldheim. For shame. I feel as though I have been tested...

My mood changed, though. I rounded one corner, and down a long alley, I espied a pale light being cast upon the cobbles. I hurried towards the light, and was rewarded when I arrived at it with a slight breeze upon my face, and the light of day, shrouded by cloud though it was, coming from a broad and slit-like rend in that steadfast darkness, somewhere very high up; I had to crane my neck upwards to take it in.

It was quite some time before my eyes adjusted, so long had it been since I had seen so much light. While I squinted and worked my lids, my ears took in the sound of the ocean crashing against the rocks, somewhere very far off. The smell of the sea was once again strong in my nares, and it filled me with strength, to again smell something organic, something not dust-covered and forgotten. There was also a low moaning, and though it was disconcerting at first, it turned out to be the wind blowing down from that opening, and into the Valdenwail, where it sang with many voices as it sped down many avenues and alleyways, shrinking as it did so. I was so refreshed to have my senses filled that the horror of my incarceration was nearly forgotten. I invoked the name of Saint Lorrigan at that time; my escape from the imperishable dusty darkness seeming an allegory to his living escape from his own unfounded grave.

By this time, I had adjusted my eyes, and took in the sight. I stood at the base of a most immutable bulwark. The blocks here were ten feet long and five feet high, and they stretched as far to the left and right as I could see. I must have been standing on some rim-road which ran along the outer, seaward wall of the Valdenwail. It was the longest bit of road I have seen in this maze of hoary stone. It was about sixty feet high, which I estimated by way of counting blocks, and at first, seemingly insurmountable. The light issued forth from an opening, presumably along the battlements at which I stood at the base of, and the opening was only forty to fifty feet wide, and then the ubiquitous darkness continued. But looking to my right and left, and screwing up my face so as to see a little farther, I noticed similar patches of light at great distances from me in either direction.

Making for the light to my left, I noticed that the streets here were not so dry and dusty. Rather, they had a very earthy smell to them, and were covered in slightly phosphorescent fungus that, when seen while standing in the now-punctuated darkness, gave off enough light to provide an outline of the ancient stone around me. It was fantastic, though spectral, and I confess that I moved along with some concern that I was walking towards some proverbial light, making my Transition through the Ghostly Realm. But then, I have not been eating or sleeping well of late, have I?

Before I came to the light, having traveled some hundred and fifty paces, I found an opening to my right – a very large archway with an open door. I peeked my head inside, and found a capacious stairway leading up. The stairs were a spiral, and ten men could easily have marched shoulder to shoulder up them. They were solid stone the entire way up, even though my circuitous journey brought me many times about; such is the architecture of the Valdenwail. At length, I climbed the last broad stair, and found

myself on a slippery, mossy landing, facing another large and unobstructed archway, and beyond, the pale grey of the ceiling of the world.

I was even more elated as I crossed that threshold, and felt the sting of the full wind on my face, its autumnal chill waking me from a dream, its saltiness like a breath taken after a long plunge. I should say it was nearly eventide, of what day I am not sure. The sun was a pale circle of lighter grey in the darker clouds. The Harbour of the Valdenwail was before me, and the violent sea beyond it was the same colour and temper as the sky, so grey and cold and roiling were they both.

The Harbour is perfect. It is a circle perhaps two miles in radius, with the Valdenwail making up one half of its circumference, and a menacing and toothy-looking craggy ridge the other. There is a small aperture in that natural wall, perhaps one hundred yards high (though it is tough to tell at this distance, and I have proven myself a most terrible judge of measurement in this confusion-inspiring realm), opposite the Valdenwail, through which a couple large ships might sail. Even from this distance, I can see that a great citadel sits atop this natural arch, so that no ship could pass unwelcome into that Harbour.

Looking down over the substantial battlements, I could take in the serenity of the Harbour below. Though the ocean raged beyond the wall, the Harbour was calm. It must be horribly and unfathomably deep, so black are those still waters. The natural precipice upon which the Valdenwail sits rises at least one hundred yards from the face of the water, and nearly straight up, until the huge blocks of the outer wall are found. At the base of this escarpment, growing out of the sea like hundreds of gnarly and broken teeth, are smaller stone protrusions; the remnants of a slowly receding cliff. They are worn to every shape thinkable, and make old things look new, so moss-covered and weather-eaten are they. And yet, upon most of them are small buildings; small only because of my great distance from them, and their relative scale beside the vast walls of the Valdenwail. Surely, those are small fortresses upon those stalagmites of the Harbour, and they are as mossy as the geologically uncertain protrusions upon which they sit. Many have vast and nearly impossible arches spanning the distance between them, so that many comprise small networks between themselves with these graceful bridges. And still many others have only partial bridges which lead out over open water. Time does pass, even here.

I have espied at least three arches that lead from some of the closer protrusions, upon which sit larger and taller fortresses; arches that lead to the cliff face upon which the Valdenwail sits. There are bridges upon them that lead to the belly of this behemoth acropolis, and, presumably, tunnels commencing therefrom, which worm their way up, unseen and unremembered.

I was shaking my head, trying to take it all in. I was again lost in the complexity and the vastness of the Valdenwail, and was again feeling the sorrow of such a monument of Man's Industry remaining all but vacant for centuries unnumbered. I had already taken for granted the feeling of the open air, and the quality of the shrouded light of the sun, when it was all sundered again. As I leaned precariously over the bulwark, I heard a door open far to my left, at the opposite end of the open portion of the battlement from which I

emerged. I could not see the origin of that bone-chilling noise, poised such as I was, with a great stone obstacle between I and it, and I made no effort at first to change this, so numb with fright was I. I heard one great armoured footfall, and knew what I would see coming out of that black portal to my left. I righted myself, and as my face slid past the stone battlement, the mailed sentinel that I was expecting did come into view by inches. He was perhaps forty feet away from me, and walking ponderously forward. His mail was similar to the other sentinels I have seen; it was bronze, and every square inch was covered in detail. This armour was quite green with moss, though, and the legs the more so. It carried a great shield and a great maul, also bronze, also detailed, mossy and green. And it wielded the same oppressive will of his fellows.

I remember quickly thinking “One open door in the whole decrepit City, and...stupid Stephan! Of course! There are no open doors in this place, unless they are opened apurpose. That thing had come that way, and must have been coming back! No more open doors for me, thank you!”

I knew at once that he viewed and labeled me as an intruder, and that he was coming to apprehend me. I made a mental plea, but it was met with the same obstinate wall of will. There was nothing for it but to run. Surely, I thought, no one in such armour would catch one as unencumbered as I.

I headed back to the black opening to the right, and back down the wide stone steps as fast as I could. In fact, I went faster than I could, and I went for a nasty tumble down several steps after slipping on some of the mossy growth that has accumulated in this part of the Valdenwail. I struck my head, and blacked out...

One could well imagine my horror upon waking, alone in the dark, a fire in my head, and the taste of blood in my mouth. It was very dark; pitch, I thought. But, it just took my eyes some time to adjust. There was the same pale light above me that I had just been making my escape in. And just then I heard the sound of heavily armoured feet above me, perhaps a few steps away. I had not been out as long as I thought, though in those few short seconds I lived a long story of horror that has probably cost me a year of my allotted time in this World. I scrambled to my feet, and made my way more cautiously down those steps, descending into perfect darkness as I did so. It was a long way down, before I hit, unexpectedly, awkwardly, and with another ungraceful fall, the bottom. This time, my chin hit the unyielding stone, and several of my teeth are chipped for it.

This, still, did not stop me. Laying prostrate in the bottom of the stairs, I was facing the opening, and saw that same pale light that brought me here in the first place, beyond the threshold. I was back at street level, and though what little light there was I would soon lose, it gave me a bearing. I got up, dashed out into the street, and turned right. I made one quick listen in the archway, and heard the ponderous report from the bronze feet. It had come only about half way down the stair.

I dashed off, heading towards the next bit of open battlement, which should have been a couple hundred yards away. It was further, and as I proceeded along, I slowed my pace,

and let my mind work again. So full of fright I was, that I had made a wrong turn after leaving the archway without thinking, and had just now run hundreds of yards THE WRONG DIRECTION! Certainly, I did not pay enough attention to Janvermin and his craft.

I knew that to try and find my path back by any other direction from that which I just came would be futile. There are absolutely no parallel or straight avenues in the Valdenwail, and though logic would dictate that I could head into the darkness of the Valdenwail for a block, and the head to the left, it would not service my cause in this maze. There was nothing to do but run back, and hopefully pass the archway a second time, before the Sentinel made the street.

I ran as fast as I ever have, for exactly four paces. My fourth pace found my foot perched precariously along the edge of an uncommonly large and protruding cobblestone, and I immediately doubled over at the ankle, and subsequently found myself sprawled out on the stone for the third time in less than a minute or so. I landed mostly on my left wrist, and now have a broken wrist to add to my list of injuries as well.

I thought about giving up, and letting the thing come to me, but just then I had, for the first time in my young life, a Sign. As I have mentioned, the stones in this long avenue are covered in a glowing moss which provides some little light. As I lay there, my head lolling to the side, my hope diminishing as my pain grew in my limbs, I looked to my right, where now was a row of the large stone houses, opposite the great bulwark to my left. All had a pale glow from the lichen, but one wall had a cluster of brighter, greenish-yellow lichens that was a perfect replica of Caanan's Cross. I cursed. I lolled my head to the left, and there, in a large sconce in the bulwark, was a likeness of St. Caanan, glowing like a lantern, though I could see no lichen upon his loathsome likeness. I cursed and spat.

"Not today, Herald of Woe!" I uttered beneath my breath. "I will not provide your entertainment today!" And I was up and on my way, hobbling as best as I could, back towards whatever fate awaited me at the stair arch.

My defiance of Caanan might have been enough, but just barely. As I was hobbling past the black doorway, the armoured form stepped from it like a spectre, one hand outstretched for me. It could not have missed me by more than an inch. I could feel its great will demanding me to stop, but I was able to put it out of my mind, and continue on.

Though I was traveling only about half as fast as a man can briskly walk, it was fast enough to put distance between me and the sentinel. I made my way back to the first opening in the bulwark that I had found, and plunged into the darkness of the streets of the Valdenwail. I was heading down the alleyway that brought me here, but to my horror, I noticed that in my excitement, I had not placed a candle at the next intersection, after my discovery of the light. This was another mistake that good Janvermin would have never permitted.

I came to a pitch black intersection, the pale light now distant behind me. I could hear the unrelenting pace of the Sentinel as it lumbered along. At the end of the long alley, I could see the silhouette of the thing as it rounded the corner. I had some time to figure out which way I had come. I walked a few blind paces into the darkness, clenching my teeth in my bloody mouth half in pain, half in anticipation of another fall and more pain. I was lucky. I found myself on some flat ground, on one of the wider and more worn of the thoroughfares of the Valdenwail. I had no candle at this point, and was entering the heart of obsidian blackness, my hands outstretched, my left leg limping along behind me, blood trickling down the back of my throat. My eyes must have been as wide as saucers, so wanting for light was I.

And I found it. As I hobbled along, I did finally notice a light off to my left. It was very distant, and I headed towards it gingerly. I did in fact find one of my candles, and though the Sentinel had made ground on me whilst I clamoured in the darkness, I was easily able to outpace the thing back to my appointed accommodations. I was then met with my next challenge.

Though I am not known as a man who does not think things through (in fact, I have been accused of quite the opposite in my time), I did leave a large, and insurmountable problem for myself in the poor laying of this plan for adventure. As I approached the last candle, now burnt nearly to the stone of the street outside of Dunvegan House (a place, by all that is madness, I was elated to see again), I noticed the dangling rope of sheets hanging by the light of the candle, right where I left it. Now, I am a lean man, and have had many long days toiling at the more bodily tasks that the Seminary demanded of me during my Investiture. But I am by no means strong under the best of circumstances. Whether I could have climbed that rope in perfect health, I will never know. I can say with certainty that I was unable to climb it after my starving incarceration, and with a sprained ankle and broken wrist, though Ignatius knows that I tried. I tried, in fact, until I was in tears with pain and desperation. I think I actually tried to use my teeth to replace my lame hand at one point, for the last thing I saw by the light of the dying candle outside the prison I was so desperately trying to enter again, was a very bloody bedsheet.

I was spared only by my ears. I took a moment to pause, and catch my breath, and I heard a resounding clicking and whooping coming towards me from somewhere within the reticent blackness of the Valdenwail. Numb. I blew out the candle, and waited and listened.

Numb it was, sure enough. I heard him get nearer and nearer, and before long I saw the light of the small candle that he bore before him. He passed like a ghost, albeit a rambling and noisy ghost that looks capable of dying a second death at any moment, at the end of the street upon which I hid, and I heard him fumble with his mess of keys. He made entry into the House. I paused, then followed in behind him, doing the best I could to be quiet, though I hobbled like a war veteran. I managed to find a chair in the corner of the parlour that was somewhat obfuscated, and pretended to sleep. He passed back out of the House, seemingly none-the-wiser.

Just as I thought I was clear of danger, I heard the diligent lumbering of the Sentinel as it walked up to the entrance of Dunvegan House, just as Numble was leaving. Surely the two saw each other, and indeed, Numble stayed for quite some time on that porch, undoubtedly having an unnatural conversation in the voiceless manner of those terrible Sentinels. Numble finally let out a gurgling laugh, and clicked off into the lightless labyrinth.

The Sentinel is still standing on that porch as I write this, and has not moved a finger.

Mid November

I am having a lucid moment just now, and feel like writing. It is madness to be kept here in the darkness, eating one soft apple a day, and drinking some wine which once tasted so sweet. I would not be surprised if they have switched the brand, finding that it is the only thing that I consume regularly, and I would not be surprised if I am just plain sick of drinking it day after day, but it is now a noxious swill to me. And it is sweet, and leaves a pang in my broken teeth.

I took a look in a mirror the other night (for I shall cease use of the word 'day' henceforth), and was terrified. I have lost a considerable amount of what little weight I began this charge with, and though I let out a chuckle at the thought, it is no funny matter that I now have Numble's build. My wrist is a terrible swollen black and blue and blotchy white mess, and my eyes are sunken quite deep into my head. My garments are a reflection of my withered flesh. They are torn and sullied in a number of ways, and I am sure they smell terrible, though the smell of all but dust is forgotten to me.

While I think of it, I shall say that I hope that Janvermin has more wisdom than he does patience. I will not be delivering my message to the Scion, and I will not be leaving the Valdenwail. I hope Vermin has left. I hope he is alive.

(Later entry, undated, quite scribbly)

I will brook no more Exonerations of St. Jack Ass, or Flatulence of St. Orifice. I must find an end to this incarceration of darkness. The Bishop was right about the Scion. He is mad!

(Much scribbling and nonsense follows for several pages. At one point, a list of 245 Saints follows, though some are obviously falsely named, such as St. Jack Ass, who is mentioned here for the second time.)

January 9, 1747

I am certain of the date, though I am sure that it was given to me as a form of medicine. I have been raving about the time for months now, and I am sure that Numble, though likely given orders to tell me nothing of the date, let a little detail slip. He was mentioning another obscure Saint, and the reason for the furtherance of my delay. I took

no notice of the name of the event. But then he said something that I did catch, as I am sure he intended.

“Yesterday was the Investiture of Saint Ignatius, and the Collegium Founding, in case you’ve lost track of time, my guest” he said, and started into a bout of coughing and rattling again, and headed for the door. I awoke from my madness in that instant, and rose quickly to follow him to the door.

“So it is January the ninth! By all the Saints, a new year has begun!” I nearly wept. I was happy and sad, and malnourished and saw a glimmer of hope, for some reason. I saw some spark that hinted to me that my deliverance was near. I looked to Numble, and I asked “What is tomorrow, good sir?”

“Nuthin’” was his curt reply. He made his way out as unceremoniously as ever.

I will meet with the Scion tomorrow. Tonight, I must clean myself as best I can, and mend these garments. I know there are some implements of tailoring in the butler’s den.

January 10.

I write this from outside the Gate of the Valdenwail. The diminutive door in the great double arch of the Gates has only recently slammed shut behind me, and the trio of Sentinels have reeled back their oppressive wills from within my head. I am over the crest, beneath the great fork-towers and arch under which I camped for days. I shall only camp one night here this time. I am on my way home, finally.

The day started as usual. I was wandering around in the candle light of Dunvegan House, though with a little more excitement than usual. Numble came in with his usual pomp, which is to say, none. I confronted him eagerly.

Numble was not carrying his usual sack of rotten food and faggot of soggy wood. He wore a pair of grey and hoary gloves which I have not seen him wearing before. He saw me, coughed and choked and roiled and creaked and groaned for some time, and then addressed me.

“You have a message from the Prelate of Saint Ignatius, you say?” he inquired. I nodded. He likes short answers, and I decided to spare my pomp for those that matter and who are more affected than insulted by it, if such people there are in this place. “Follow” he said, and he lit another candle and made his way out the door. He stopped on the doorstep outside, and turned back in, to see that I was following. That is the nicest gesture that he ever made towards me.

Follow I did. The first thing I noticed was the absence of the Sentinel at my doorstep. I have not thought on it for quite some time, and I must confess that I am not sure if he left days or months after my roguish journey.

Numble lead me through miles of veiled street, through avenues even broader than before, and through great gates in thick walls. Back through time we seemed to journey; the architecture became more simple and prodigious as we journeyed, and the choking dustiness seemed to hit a peak somewhere partway through that twilight journey. At a couple points, we passed by streets down which I could see daylight shining, and at one point, we even walked through an open-air garden. There was a great opening above, and though it dripped at its edges from a recent rain, the sun was shining through as bright as I have seen it in this Ecclesiarchy. Though the journey was filled with greater wonders and mysteries, and seemed to grow more optimistic as we proceeded, I should add that we did not encounter another soul on that journey, nor even heard or saw a sign of one.

Finally, we arrived at a great manor home, similar to Dunvegan House in its opulence and size. It was covered by the same road-roof as the rest of the Valdenwail, but there were torches burning at all corners of the place, and several lights on inside. The sight of bright light in those windows was so encouraging that I gave a veritable laugh, and straightened my weatherworn jacket, and propped my soiled hat. I noticed that standing in one curtain was a silhouette of a man, with his hand over his eyes, likely straining to see into the darkness through the panes of glass. He must have seen us, for as we approached, he turned away.

I should boast that I knew I would not meet the Scion, as soon as we approached the main door to this House (Grimwood House, Numble called it). There were no Sentinels around, and I am sure that a meeting with Him would have been preceded by a scrutiny of those voiceless devils-in-bronze. There was none.

Numble rattled right up to the door, rapped it three times, and withdrew, hanging his head low as he did. My heart was racing, and I clutched the sealed letter in my hand tightly as I heard someone deftly turn a half dozen latches and bolts. The door opened, and though the light that issued forth immediately blinded me, I soon found that I was standing face to face with a man.

The man was about my height, being not too tall, and was slender, though not as slender as this messenger in my emaciated condition such as it is now. He wore a yellow gown with no markings at all. The man had a face like a yellow stone that has been polished by aeons of tides washing over it. His skin was taught and flawless, though not the hue of those I am used to. He had great bright blue eyes, and for hair, a single lock issuing forth from a knot at the upper occipital region of his skull, and this was a venerable silver white. I cannot guess that man's age, but if I were forced to put some borders around his age, I should say between twenty and two hundred.

He looked young, except for the silver hair, though the look in his eyes was so full of wisdom that I thought he carried a thousand years behind them. I could not look him in the eye for long. He wore an expression as gentle and benign as I can imagine, though he looked somewhat troubled. It was he who spoke first.

“I am Doctor Gideon. You are Envoy Dunmorrow, and I understand you have been waiting to carry out your charge for quite some time.” His voice was deep and level and carried the most intoned understanding I have encountered in a Human voice. “You should know that we have not kept you waiting for months on end for the purpose of testing your resolve”

I was curious that he mentioned ‘testing’. Since I have awakened from my madness, I have long contemplated this very issue of ‘testing’. I wondered if the inhabitants of this place were testing me by placing books in Dunvegan House to see if I would take the time to read them and study them. I wondered if the single open window was left to see if I would make a thorough examination of the place, and also to see if I would take the chance of an exploration of the Valdenwail. Perhaps they left the door to the battlements open to see if I would take it. Perhaps it has all been a test, and though I have not made a flawless effort, having descended most ashamedly into madness for some time, I have not failed, for here I am talking with Doctor Gideon.

I shall make a quick note about what I knew of the Doctor. I half expected to meet him. If there are any rumours and gossip coming out of the Valdenwail, it all centres around this enigmatic paragon. He is the personal physician to the Scion, and also his most trusted advisor. He is the only resident of the Valdenwail that comes to the Conclave that is accessible, and it is this one man who all the Upper Clergy, from Bishops to Prelates, of nearly every Saint at Conclave, attempt to engage and sway. Having met him in his own home, I can now see what a wise choice the Scion has made in this man. As I have said, he is a physical dubiety, appearing so old and young at once. But his manner and bearing would make the most puissant diplomat feel like a stammering lout, though he is full of such understanding that none could feel wronged by any conversation with the man.

And, he answers nothing.

He continued in his explanation. “You must understand that this place, the Valdenwail, is the very last refuge of Ceremony and Tradition. We are the last guardians of our beleaguered Faith, and though many of our Observances may seem antiquated, if not contrived, to outsiders, each one is as important as Conclave. We do not waver in our Venerations, as dictated by the Canonical Calendar, for any event or person, though fire may fall from the sky, or kings show up at our gates.” He smiled a troubled but understanding smile, and I was disarmed. I made a stammering dismissal of any charges of ill treatment, and thanked him a dozen times for a dozen small courtesies, and finally we got to the business at hand.

“Good Sir” I began. I was about to deliver my prepared oration, when I was cut off, again, from doing so. No one in this Ecclesiarchy seems interested in hearing my carefully prepared allocution. The Doctor smiled, and brought his hands up, to make the same gesture that parents use to tell their children to ‘keep it down’.

“I know you have come to deliver a message from the Seat of your Cannon, to the Scion, and likely to the Scion and no other. I am loath to tell you that I must put a terrible decision before you; to deliver the message to me, or to none. None may hold host with the Scion in this Age, I regretfully say to you. I am the Scion’s most trusted assistant, however, and I swear to you that I will deliver this message, swiftly and without compromising the most sanctimonious seal found thereupon. You can trust to me, or bring your message back undelivered.” He smiled. I placed the letter in his hand. He gracefully bowed, and placed it in his robe most carefully.

The hospitality of Grimwood House was a great improvement over Dunvegan House. I was brought in and fed a hearty though plain meal of fresh breads and cheese, and once again, fantastic wine. We sat sipping the blood-warming wine, while he listened to me talk about the outside world. He was hungry for any information that I could provide, and I confess that I let slip a good many rumours and privileged information that I should not have. The man has a way of listening to your words before you even speak them, and he seems to steer my words through some guile or strength of will that I cannot understand. He said nothing for several hours, while I ran on, unchecked, about affairs abroad.

Now that I am sitting here beneath the weather-beaten arch of the fork towers, I realize that perhaps my tongue was loosened with several tools; a long and lonesome incarceration with no one to converse with, bottles of excellent wine, a hearty meal after a long fast. These are excellent tools with which to get one to speak. Though I feel like I may have been falsely played, and harshly used, I still can’t help but feel a great exhilaration at being free of this letter, free of the timeless walls and unceasing darkness and solitary incarceration. Though the rain is falling upon me, and the wind once again stabbing at me, and though I have a long and perilous journey ahead of me, the worst is over, and I am now bound for home.

Adnihilo Inter Nos

**On the Inculcation of the Nameless Immigrants from
The Abyss into the Societie of Men in Avilund**

And

**The Recommended Rites and Treatments for Cases of
Possession**

Including

**Illuminations of Selected Known Cases of Possession
and Demonic Influence and the Deserved Resolutions
to these Incursions**

**Penned by Inquisitor-Cardinal Hanzig Van Tassel,
Prelate of St. Kerrigan**

With

**Holy Permission Granted by His Most Holy Scion,
Baudri Avitus Vanderwail**

**In the Imperial Year of Thirteen Hundred and Fourty
Seven**

Preface

It is most common to hear the utterance in any City, Town, Village, Hamlet and Cottage of the Empire, the terrible and loathsome word "Demon". Most men and women, including those of Breeding and Education, are ignorant of the truth of that word, "Demon", and use it to label nearly every type of nuisance and unpalatable creature or happening that besets them. However, blessed are the ignorant, and blessed are the deeds that spring from their fears and grievances. Surely, for every hundred cries of "Demon", there is one cry that rings true, and it is up to the servants of the Saintry to investigate every cry and plea with due vigilance and prejudice, and find what true demons do lurk at the edge of the shadow of fear. It is the charge of the Ordo Calculus Veritas to be the eyes and ears of the Saintry Faith, and to be its hammer when the demon is found. In our Sacred Duty, we must not forget that it is only through brutal prejudice and merciless hunting for our prey that we may clean the taint of the Children of the Abyss from the Empire, and though a hundred innocent men and women might bleed before the demon is uncovered, we must accept that their deaths are more acceptable than the life of one demon.

Adnihilo Taxonomie

It is not vital for the Inquisitor, least of all the Inquisitor-Innovitiae, to see the demon amongst his flock. If there be common complaint of demon and demonic doings, it is well that the Inquisitor find what **might be** the demon, and put an end to it by whatever means are available him. Trial and drowning are preferred, but fire, the rope, the blade and the mob are all viable tools for the meting out of the demon, or the supposed-demon, and his minions. It is better that one person suspected of demonic cavorting or demonic hosting be slain, though no proof be found, than any body of people be left wanting for justice and safety. Again, if one hundred suspects are put to water or fire or blade, surely, one or more demons will be sent permanently from this world.

However, the Inquisitor beset by more complaints and grievances than he can possibly address must know in which way to steer his gaze, for surely, most people do not know a demon from their kin in most cases, and it is often the case that the most terrible of fiends is never detected by any BUT the inquisitor. The commoner might call a cagey rat, which he is unable to capture season after season, a demon. He may call a terrible storm a demon. He may think his deranged sister a demon. He may call the Feral up in the hills a demon, or the sorcerer or witch a demon. It is well that common men make such complaints and charges so commonly, for it acts as a natural barrier to the proliferation of those Abyssal Spawne, but the Inquisitor may have to sort through these multitudinous 'demons' to find the genuine article, and dispense with it. There are some blessed few Men and Women of the Empire who are demon-sighted, and can spot them and their works immediately, as though they were illuminated in an unnatural and conspicuous light. However, the Inquisitor not so-gifted must rely upon the **Prayer of Guidance** to identify the demon.

The genuine demon is born of the Abyss, and finds its way to our World through some few portals that open at significant times, or through the invitation by mortal souls of this World. The demon may come to our World with either bodily or spiritual form, and it is likely that some lack any natural bodily form, and need the Earthly host for their works.

Of those demons with bodily form, there are countless different species and sizes ranging from that of a large rat, to those of gigantic proportions. They may have any number of limbs, heads, eyes, hands, legs, claws and so forth, but the Ordo encounters a preponderance of those that are roughly the size and composition of Men, no doubt owing to their desire to blend into our Societie, and their ability to change their form in this world. Though many have but one form in our World, there are some few who can change forms and sizes, and these provide the greatest challenge for the Inquisitor.

Many demons come to our World in their soul-form only, and seek out the bodies of victims or willing supplicants to possess. These also provide a great challenge for the Inquisitor, but they may often be dealt with by the Brethren of St. Ignatius, who are known as Exorcists of the First Order. It is most often the case that a demon-soul forced from its host will return to the Abyss, but there are some powerful few who might go from body to body before they are dispatched. These are the most problematic, and require the assistance of other Canons to dispense with. It is well that the Inquisitor destroy any potential hosts, and possibly-willing supplicants, with or without proof of such, before the Exorcism is performed. Such was the case in Hamstonfast in 1021, and though the Empire reeled at the success of Brother-Inquisitor Dredfalls efforts, the demon in that case was banished.

The powers of the Demon are many, and many are uncharted. Most are resistant to the flame, which makes it an excellent tool for the discovery of these fiends. Though Dredfall calls for the complete immolation of suspects by flame, it is often only necessary to burn a limb or two in order to determine if the suspect be of demonic origin or not. Many demons of the Greater Order have great powers over the mind, and in all cases, the Inquisitor must approach Suspects under the **Rite of Sanctity**, girding also his retinue, if possible. It is common for the Demon to possess the power of flight, or of levitation, and these are problematic creatures to be sure. The Inquisitor is advised to keep at least one marksman in his retinue in order to end the flight of such creatures.

The demon is likely to be of great strength for its size, and of great speed for its bearing. This will often surprise the victims of the creature, and so the Inquisitor

must always expect any Suspect to possess such peerless strength and speed, and prepare to counter it.

The Greater Order of demons all have some control over one or more of the Constituents, many of which master Fire. Records of demons with control over all 5 of the Constituents exist, and so the Inquisitor must prepare to battle against all of them. There are no records of a single demon possessing power over more than one Constituent, and so it is that the Inquisitor is directed to use both the Flame and the Water to seek out and exterminate the demon. The scattering of ashes of demons and Suspects into a flowing river is recommended, and the immolation of one drowned is likewise called for. It is well that the People see both of these actions carried out, so that they may employ these Elements on their own in time of great need and no Inquisitorial presence.

The demons greatest weapon is fear, and it is for this reason that the Inquisitor must both master his own fears, and learn to wield fear himself. It is better for the People to fear the Inquisitor, who is pure and true, than to fear the demon, who is black and malign. Those who fear the Inquisitor more than the demon will do the Inquisitors bidding, rather than contrawise, and this is well. It is well that an Inquisitor make a terrible entertainment in Public of the first Suspect that is found in his investigation, and that no Man, Woman or Child be allowed to look away. They must see that the fate of the demon is terrible, as is the fate of those that would host, or assist the demon in any way. This fate should also be implicated for those who would not help the Inquisitor. If the People **know** the wrath of the Inquisition, they will prefer the **unknown** wrath of the demon, and thus cast their efforts as well as they are able to the cause of the Inquisitor, which is in fact, the cause of the Goode of the People, whether they know it, or they know it not.

Hamstonfast, 31 October, 1021

Brother-Inquisitor Dredfall it was who was selected to investigate the terrible goings on in the doomed village of Hamstonfast in One-Thousand and Twenty-One. Reports of a cult of Black Faith in that town were many, and given the proximity of the place to Irenaeus, it was suspected that a cult of Ultan had been uncovered. However, Inquisitor-

Prelate Motican identified in the reports some articles which ruled out the likelihood of the Ultanites, and suggested a straight-forward, albeit markedly dangerous, demon-worshipping cult. The reports suggested that there would not be a Man in the Empire capable of withstanding the will of the demon that plagued Hamstonfast. And so it was that Dredfall was chosen; his will was unmatched, even by Mortican; Dredfall, when once charged with being a demon himself, used a hot brand to burn the entirety of the Prospectus Imperialis Ex Daemonica onto his legs, arm and chest, though the pain of it must have been unrivaled.

When Dredfall arrived in Hamstonfast, he found he could muster the aid of not a single villager, so great was their fear of the demon that had taken every third child and woman from that village for its entertainments in the hills nearby. Dredfall had to make a grisly display of eleven villagers before he could convince the rest to assist him and his retinue.

The investigation was a protracted affair, and at every encounter with the beast (who he came to know as Gazzlemast), he was unable to keep his retinue and the mob in good order, and they often set upon themselves, killing each other in the most terrible fashion, while Dredfall pursued the demon. It is an ugly legend that Dredfall put the entire village to the flame himself, but in fact, more than one third of the village had died in assisting the Inquisitor in his investigation, before the final confrontation with Gazzlemast.

On October 31, 1021, Dredfall had set up a trap for the beast in the heart of the village, where the All Hallows Feast was still set to be enjoyed by the villagers. As expected, the arrogant and confident demon appeared right in the midst of the people at the festival, however, Dredfall had enlisted the help of an Ignatian, who had drawn a Great Circle encompassing the entire festival. The people were immune to the will of Gazzlemast, and he could likewise not make an escape by any means. However, the demon revealed that it had the power of possession, and though its black and terrible body fell to the blades of the mob, its soul entered a villager, who immediately set upon his neighbours. As one possessed villager was slain, the demon took command of another body. Dredfall ordered what remained of his retinue to begin destroying the villagers, and it is a credit to the will and reputation of

the man, and the obedience of his retinue, that they carried out his orders, for certainly some of them must have known that their fate had been cast in that circle. As the remaining mortal souls grew fewer and fewer, the demon began to panic, and it attempted to take command of Dredfall himself. While the two of them struggled in the Realm of the Mind, the last of the villages was being slain. At length, but a single member of Dredfall's retinue remained; the Ignatian who had devised the circle, and while Dredfall held the last villager in his clutches of his hands, and the demon and he held each other in the clutches of each other's will, Dredfall ordered the Ignatian to destroy himself. When the Ignatian fell to the ground with his own sword in his belly, Dredfall broke the neck of the final villager, and Gazzlemast had nowhere left to flee, and was banished from this World.

This event has been recast in a terrible light over the years, but the Inquisitor must look to the will and determination of Dredfall, and take inspiration from his unwavering commitment to his course of action.

The City of Avitus

A Short Guide to the Main Neighbourhoods

The Old City (aka Elderton, or Saints' Island)

Located on Saints' Island at the confluence of the rivers Wen and Nith at Calder's Basin, this was the original site of the Elder City of Avitus. The oldest part of the city, the island is home to Imperial Square where the Cathedral of St Avitus, the Monastery of St Avitus, The Blue Palace of the Scion and The Palace of Saint Severinius line its sides. This has always been the traditional power centre of the city. For most of its history, the city was confined to the islands themselves, with nothing but farmland and brush on the mainland.

Sebald's Isle & Elder Isle

Adjacent to Saints' Island, Sebald's and Elder have long been the residential neighbourhoods of the city. As the city grew out in size unto the mainland, these two islands traditionally had been the location of the palaces and villas of various prelates, nobles and wealthy merchants. However, with the continued expansion and growth of the city out of the islands and onto the mainland, many of these have moved their residences to larger estates in the newer suburbs to the north, particularly to Newton Hill where the floodwaters of the River Wen do not reach. Today, Sebald's and Elder remain as largely residential neighbourhoods, although many of the palaces have since been gutted and subdivided into smaller houses and tenements now populated by members of the growing middle

class.

Civic (aka The Fleet)

This district, located directly across from the islands on the eastern shore, used to be called "The Fleet", after its most storied resident, the Imperial Navy. Home to the original docks and shipyards of the Navy, this was a raucous, violent and impoverished neighbourhood for most of the city's history. With the coming of the Revolution, the new government chose The Fleet as the site of its new administrative and government centre, deciding to move it away from the church's influence in the Old City. It was hoped, as well, that by demolishing many of the slums and dark alleys of The Fleet, the neighbourhood might be invested with some semblance of respectability. In an attempt to buff up the image of the district, the city's new rulers renamed it "Civic Centre" and eventually "Civic" for short. However, there is not a man alive or dead in the city that calls this district by either of those names. This district has always been known as The Fleet, and continues to be referred to only by that name regardless of how the new maps have been labeled. It is of interest to note that, to date, virtually none of the improvements originally planned for this district have come to pass. Construction of the Parliament House and other government buildings has been slow and irregular throughout the centuries. Aside from the relative safety of the main thoroughfares, The Fleet remains one of the most vile, debauched, dangerous and dirty districts in the whole city.

Lord's

Originally the site of a large estate, this district to the north-west of The Fleet, and north of the islands on the shore is now largely composed exclusively of the University and its associated buildings and institutions. Although sitting on the banks of the River Wen, Lord's has the advantage of being located atop a small series of hills, and thus, is typically spared much damage whenever the Wen floods.

Sever's Cross

This district, located east of Lord's and north of The Fleet, is the main commercial and trades district of the city. Sever's Cross is both residential and commercial, densely housing many of the city's more prosperous tradesmen and shops in large five and six storey buildings. A reasonably clean, safe and neatly maintained district, the old town of Sever's Cross is where most of the city's middle and upper classes come to shop, dine and seek entertainment in its theatres, clubs, bordellos and taverns. Sever's Cross also houses most of the city's markets, except for livestock (located, appropriately, in the district of Hog's Market) and fish (located at the Harbour).

Newton Hill

Located on a hill overlooking the city to the north of Sever's Cross and Lord's, Newton (or "New Town") is a sleepy, residential neighbourhood of large villas and palaces surrounded by clean parks and gardens. This is the wealthiest

district in the city, and houses most of the city's upper class, prelates and nobles. The buildings here tend to be crowded around squares, and are palatial in appearance and size.

Northlund Road

Not a district as such, but more of a collection of villages and buildings lining the road north of the city along the east bank of the River Wen as it leaves Lord's and Newton. Northlund Road is what one might expect, housing a variety of tradesmen, shops, houses, inns, stockyards and houses of varying qualities and becoming more and more rural as it goes along.

The Green

The Green is a large, cultivated forest and park that marks the northern boundary of the city, and melds out into the wilderness. Near the city, The Green is mostly parklands and gardens, with the occasional farm. As it rolls out further north, the Green becomes wilder, and transforms into a forest. This forest is reserved exclusively as a hunting ground for the city's elite, though, in its wilder areas it is said to house escaped convicts and bands of other criminals.

Methwold

Located south of The Green, and east of Newton, this is another fairly well-to-do neighbourhood housing estates and villas of the nobility. Unlike Newton, the homes in Methwold tend to be much more spread out, reminiscent of country estates, rather than palaces.

The Harbour

South of Methwold and east of Sever's Cross across Severn Harbour, lies the district known only, and appropriately, as The Harbour. This is precisely what its name implies, holding the majority of the city's current docks, shipyards and warehouses. It is a largely industrial neighbourhood with little to offer outside of the nautical professions and associated trades (and even then the brothels and taverns of Sever's Cross are preferred by the sailors themselves.) Aside from this, The Harbour is also home to the city's main fish market.

Waverleigh, Chapelton & Pondluck

Located east of the harbour, the neighbourhoods of Waverleigh, Chapelton and Pondluck are, perhaps, indistinguishable from one another. They are poor, dirty, industrial districts which house most of the city's working poor. These neighbourhoods are home to the multitude masses of the city, and are punctuated by the black smoke of the factory fires. While it is not unusual for the more affluent citizens of the city to look down with scorn at these poor neighbourhoods, those with any bit of sense recognise that this is the necessary industrial engine that drives the city.

Saint Gideon

This neighbourhood is considered to be the latest casualty of the city's

expansion. Prior to the Revolution, Saint Gideon was a prosperous town in its own right. These days, however, it has been swallowed up by the greater city of Avitus, and now forms one of its northern suburbs. Unlike many of the other neighbourhoods of the city, Saint Gideon retains much of its independent charm and character. It has its own town square, and its own hall, and retains its own town council. Many of Saint Gideon's wealthy elite have moved on to the nearby suburbs of Methwold and Newton, but many remain. Saint Gideon, in many ways, is as industrial an area as neighbouring Waverleigh, but it is decidedly cleaner and more prosperous in character.

The Marshes

The Marshes was built, appropriately, over drained marshland on the banks of the River Nith just to the east of Chapelton and Pondluck. The Marshes is a district that remains as poor as Chapelton and Pondluck, but, unlike those two, is rife with mass unemployment. The soft ground of The Marshes prevents the construction of buildings of any great size, so the factories and workhouses have not come here. This is perhaps the most impoverished district in the city.

Saint Pitt's Town

Like Saint Gideon, Saint Pitt's Town was an independent town that was annexed into the larger city over time. Unlike Saint Gideon, Saint Pitt's did not maintain its independent feel. Today, Saint Pitt's is a collection of stockyards, abandoned buildings, impoverished monasteries, and military barracks. Saint Pitt's only asset is that this is where some of the crusading orders gather, within easy distance of the necessary supply shops, but far enough away from the sinful temptations that may befall the young recruits. Saint Pitt's however, is a transient town. A waystation between the provinces and Lysander for these crusaders.

Landside & The Spit

Located south of the Harbour on the appropriate spit of land, these neighbourhoods are old, crumbling, and hold a mixture of impoverished citizens and prosperous tradesmen. Landside is a cousin to The Harbour, holding many warehouses, along with the tenements and inns that hold the sailors and fishermen that work out of the Harbour. The Spit, however, is undergoing a bit of a renaissance. Linked to The Fleet and the islands by boatmen, barges and ferries, The Spit has become a fashionable district for the young and ambitious merchants of the city. Buying up property at a very cheap price in this district, many of these young men have turned this narrow strip of land into the financial centre of the city. Indeed, it is here that the Bank of Avitus is now located, and where the Exchange's building is under construction. With these young men and their businesses came the requisite service trades. New tea houses, taverns, restaurants and clubs have been opened up in remodeled buildings that had been left abandoned or condemned. Nowhere else in the city is there so much construction and optimism as in The Spit.

Highborough & Farmwalk

Located on the south bank of the River Nith, across the ferry from Landside and The Spit, Highborough is a city that grew up independently in its own right. It continues this independence today, being formally apart from Avitus. With its smaller suburb of Farmwalk, Highborough is actually little more than a middling market town serving the majority of the farmers on the south bank of the river. It is also the start of the Lysander Road, and as such, houses a great many inns.

Kingston (aka King's, The Bride, Hog Market & Black's Road)

Kingston was a city on the west bank of the River Wen, across from Avitus. No longer called "Kingston", since the Revolution, the western districts have been formally annexed into the city. The four western districts are a tumultuous, virtually lawless place of stockyards, slaughterhouses, animal pens, factories, coachhouses and seedy inns and brothels. Only the district of Hog's Market (site of both the city's live animal market, and the city's meat markets) holds any real degree of safety and security. This safety is brutally enforced by the district's Butchers Guild, who fear that crime and lawlessness may drive the city's rulers to establish a new livestock market elsewhere. The central district, referred to as King's, is no more than an impoverished commercial centre full of slums and decaying buildings. The Bride, which is the northern suburb, is a mostly residential area not unlike the Northlund Road district on the opposite bank of the river. Black's Road, which marks the westernmost part of the city, is the main point of entry for all who come from the western country. Named after a famous highwayman who terrorized the western road, the district of Black's Road is composed mostly of taverns, public houses, inns, coach-houses, caravan yards and animal pens servicing all who come in and out of the city.

A Note on the Waterways

The city is characterized by its four main bodies of water: The large and navigable River Nith leading out to the sea; the fast and rough River Wen flowing down from the northern mountains; the safe calm of Severn Harbour; and the cold, deep whirlpools of the Calder Basin. Much of the city's life revolves around the waterways. Countless boatmen and ferries ply their trade from any available spot on the banks in the absence of adequate bridges. A great multitude of floating shops can be found in Severn Harbour and along the banks of the Nith or between the isles, plying their trades from their boats and skiffs. While not a nautical culture, the rivers and waterways do play a fairly important part in the life of the city.

A Note on Floods

The River Wen often floods. However, it must be noted that the floods are almost invariably manmade in nature. Occassionally, heavy rains or a particularly wet winter in the north will cause the Wen to swell and break its banks, but, most often, when the Wen floods it is due to garbage and debris creating a dam out of the bridge linking Lord's to King's.

When the river floods as a result of this carelessness, most of the water flows to the lower west bank, submerging King's and The Bride and, to a lesser extent, the other Kingston suburbs. A gully separates the hills of Lord's and Newton Hill creating a virtual canal along Lord's Road that funnels a great deal of the flood water down into The Fleet and out into the harbour and basin.

The manmade floods of the Wen are a perpetual annoyance, though, few efforts at fixing the situation have ever found success. The latest effort (undertaken last in the last century) saw the government construct a large underground canal directly beneath Lord's road from the bridge on the Wen to the Customs House in the harbour, which, it was hoped, would channel the excess water away. It was a solution that worked, until the canal became just as clogged with refuse and debris as the bridge itself, that is.

At present, The Fleet (that is, the Imperial Navy, not the district) has the responsibility of keeping the arches under the bridge and the Lord's Road Canal clear of debris. A worrisome situation, given the Navy's tendency to subcontract to the lowest bidders.

History Primer for Students of the Humanities Lord's University.

**Penned by Dr. Eustace Worthope
In the Imperial Year of 1738.**

Preface

This volume is intended to make the Student of Humanities in the great University of Waldheim prepared for rudimentary discussions of History. The Knowledge contained herein is assumed knowledge for any Student of the Humanities, and will not be further illuminated in any lectures by the Professors at Lord's. This volume is chiefly concerned with the History of the Early Middle Period (c. 1700 BC to 1400 BC) to the present day. There will be some discussion of Early History, which is often referred to as Elder History.

The Knowledge found herein is a compilation from a few significant sources that survived the *Repurgo Imperialis*. Chief amongst these is the *Magnus Corpus Avitus* which was provided by the Seminary of St. Ignatius, most generously and graciously. Other significant primary sources include the *Treatise on the Historical Relevance of the "Tale of the Woodland King"*, the *Chronicle of Vermilund*, and the remnants of the *Corpus Officina Hominum per Gestalt Avarinius*. Numerous other texts and sources are also cited, and are noted appropriately.

On Calendars

For the most part, this volume will reference events using the Imperial Calendar (IC). The 'zero' year of this Calendar is marked by the conquest of the **City of Waldheim** by **Saint Abaddon**. The city was called **Gulfziam** by the Ferals that populated it at that time. It is important to note that the IC was started and restarted many times, and the City changed hands between the Ferals and Men for hundreds of years before

Abaddon. The Imperial Calendar year zero also marks the beginning of the period of history known as the **Saeculum Dominae Humanitas a Avilund**, which persists to this day, according to some scholars (some rogues disagree, but that is an issue for modern Civics seminars). Time before year zero is noted as 'Before Conquest', or 'BC', and counts backwards from year zero.

Before the IC, the Men of Avilund marked a new chronicle of years which began with the landing of **Sebald, Dunstan** and **Barnabas** in the lands that are now known as the Imperial Ecclesiarchy of Valdenwail. What they called their own calendar is a fact lost to us in the *Repurgo*, but it shall herein, and in most lectures, be referred to as the SHA Calendar, after the period of history known as the **Saeculum Humanitas a Avilund**, which persists to this day, as per discussion above. It is likely that the conquest of Gulfziam by Abaddon was in, or close to, the year 1400 SHA. This puts us very close to the 3150th year of Men in Avilund.

What calendar, if any, was used by the Men that came before Sebald and his crew is a matter for speculation in the post-*Repurgo* world of academics.

The Elder Roll of Years (ERY) will be referenced from time to time. It is not known to modern scholars if the Elders counted years the same way we do, but it is assumed that they called the same revolution of the four seasons one year, as we do. The Seminary of St. Ignatius, after decades of research, insists that the **Collegium Waldheim** were made aware of the ERY in their historic visitation to Waldheim in the year 201 SHA. At this time, they record that the ERY was in its 39,999th year. This puts us at around the 42,900th year of the Elder Roll of Years. This number is, admittedly, overwhelming.

Periods of History

There are several conventions for the naming of periods of History, and there has been very little standardized procedure for this practice, even recently, in post-*Repurgo* academics. Different groups with their own interests have identified dozens of different ways to break up our Historical Record. As one can well imagine, canonical texts break most of our History down by the activities of the Saints. Secular organizations choose more far-reaching and important landmarks in History to identify 'periods' or 'eras'. Of course, many different periods overlap as a result of this. It is convention, however, in educated circles, to refer to the following periods of History as being the most definitive;

Early History. This is the period of time before Men came to Avilund. It includes the activities of the Elders in Avilund, and the activities of Men on the Islands, though not much is now known about either of these groups and their doings.

Middle History. This is the period of time in which the lives of the first Saints were lived, including the time of Men coming to Avilund, and up to the conquest of Gulfziam by Abaddon. Some antiquarians draw the curtain on 'Middle History' with the final destruction of the Elders, which was around 1199 BC (201 SHA). At Lord's University, it is understood that an Educated Man is referring to the years circa 1700 BC to 0 IC as 'Middle History'.

Early Middle History. This is the most nebulous of historical periods, after Elder History. This period is chiefly concerned with the lives of Avitus, Gaul, and the Prime Saints. This period of history is now shrouded in complete obscurity after the *Repurgo*. No actual dates have survived to modern times about the events of this age, and of the events described in the *Tale of the Woodland King*. This age ends in 1400 BC, when Men arrive in Avilund.

Mezzo Middle History. This is the period of time from 1400 BC to 450 BC. This age is sometimes called the **First Age of Imperial Expansion**. It begins with the arrival of Sebald, Dunstan and Barnabas in the legendary vessel known as *Bram'Cairn*. This age, the Saeculum Humanitas a Avilund, marks a tremendous expansion of Men on this continent. In this thousand or so years, Men came to

Avilund, and managed to establish the Imperial Ecclesiarchy, and the Imperial boundaries that are, for all intents and purposes, the same as they are today. Some notable dates in this period of history include the following;

1250 BC	Birth of the Primus Deus Fidelis and the laying of the first stones at the Valdenwail.
1199 BC	Founding of the Collegium Waldheim by Ignatius, Anselm and Gratus .
450 BC	Invasion of Brogard the Cruel. The ancient city of Tiberwail (the location of the modern day city of Lysander) is destroyed, and the Horde marches up to the walls of the Valdenwail. The <i>Epic of Lazarus of Duneedin</i> tells this tale pretty well, and the head of Brogard can still be viewed in the Cathedral of St.Lazarus in Duneedin today.

Although the huge feral Horde lead by Brogard was defeated, the Empire had been crippled and nearly destroyed. The unchecked advance of Men in Avilund had come to a halt, and a period of slow rebuilding followed.

Late Middle History. 450 BC to 0. This short bit of history is characterized by the worse times that Men in Avilund ever had to endure. The slow reclaiming of Imperial territories was difficult. Not only had the Ferals taken root in many lands, but the new inhabitants of the Eastern shores of Avilund, the **Kells**, had arrived. These warlike, robust and violent men of the Eastern Archipelago were very cunning and determined foes, and remain on this continent today, though in the far North. This is a brief period of history, but one which produced many heroes and saints. Chief among the heroes and saints of this time is Abaddon, the Liberator of Waldheim. Though he invaded the Feral-held City no less than 13 times, in the year 0, he took it, and it has not left the control of Men since.

Late History. This is the period of time from year 0 IC to the present day. It is a tumultuous time for Men and for Empire, and it can be divided into dozens, even hundreds of significant periods of time. However, there are, like Middle History, three commonly acknowledged subdivisions of this period.

Early Late History. 0 to 750. This age is also known as the **Second Age of Imperial Expansion**. This age is typified by very strong Scions and Prelates with warlike personalities and the wills to match. Great Pilgrimages and Crusades happen during this time. Previous to the *Repurgo*, this was the most widely studied period of History. It is during this time that Men begin to unearth the libraries and relics of the Elders in Waldheim and other Elder Cities. **New Magic** was studied and employed by Men, and it is from this time that most Artifacts originate. This was a violent time, but a time of great advances for the culture of Men and acts of great heroism. Colonies were established in the Eastern Archipelago and in the lands beyond the Barrier Wood and the Sea of Sorrow.

This golden age of Men ended in 750 when the **Black Faith** first reared its hideous face. We know that the Scion **Nicetus Avitus Vanderwail** (700-804) revealed the **Prospectus Imperialus ex Daemonica** in November of 750. This document was a heavy handed policy that gave birth to the **First Inquisition**.

Middle Late History. 750-1348. With the birth of the Inquisition, the Empire of Men ceased it's expansion immediately, and quickly lost ground to the Ferals, Kells, and other inhabitants of the lands in the new colonies. This age is typified by the tyranny of the Scions (with some exceptions), and the crumbling of the Society and Culture of Men. The hallmarks of this terrible time are illuminated most clearly during the **Repurgo Imperialis**. This 138-year tragedy begins in 1210 in the little-known hamlet of Sandalstone, where the Casparian Monk, David, emerged with his torch and hatred for all things academic. Though the *Repurgo* was started by a crazed vigilante, it soon had a powerful ally in the **Second Inquisition**, which was called for in 1295 by **Baudri the Bloody, Baudri Avitus Vanderwail** (1210-1350). This time is characterized by the horrible misdeeds of Men against Men, and though it was a time

of conflagration for records, books, documents and all other forms of history, enough documents and tales about this time survived its own fires.

Middle Late History ends in 1348 with the **Novae res Sanquinius**. There is an entire sub-specialty of History that deals with the Revolution, from its causes to its effects upon the modern world, and this volume will not go into much of that detail. The Student of the Humanities is encouraged to read Dr. Carrington's *Cruentus Novae res Sanquinius Satus Compleo* for a greater understanding of this monumental turning point in history. It must be understood at this point, though, that the Empire as it was came to an end during this Revolution, and the power of the Saintly Faith dwindled dramatically in many parts of what was the Empire. The Empire, as it had been, was changed for ever, and some rogues actually insist that it came to an end outside the Hedge of the Valdenwail, when Baudri signed the *Placitum a Terminus Potentia*, on October 30, 1348. This document relinquished the control of the City of Avilund (modern day Waldheim) from the hands of the Vanderwails, and brought an end to the rule of the Saintly Faith in all but a few territories. If it had not been for the bloody policies of Baudri's Inquisition, this might never have happened.

Modern History. 1348-present. After the *Placitum* was signed, the Empire changed dramatically, and the whole face of Avilund was re-sculpted. This era is marked at its beginning by the end of the Revolution in 1348, but just as characteristic of this age is the renewed interest in the Holy Archipelago (the Eastern Archipelago) and the lost colonies in the West. The 3rd Crusade was launched in 1350 by Baudri, and in 1488, the Fourth Crusade was launched by **Eustace Avitus Vanderwail**, who is known as the **Crusading Scion**. Many old laws were repealed in many parts of Avilund (at this point, most scholars except the most proud use the term 'Avilund' rather than 'Empire' to refer to the lands of Men on the continent), and a new age of invention and discovery soon took hold, and was promptly labeled the **Saeculum Ingenium Aurum** by scholars here at Lord's. In many places, the City of Waldheim especially, Institutions of Learning again sprung up, though this was a slow process; the long years of the *Repurgo* and its infection in the psyche of Avilund had made a lasting and durable obstacle to progress. This age is typified by such things as the great inventions of Gun Powder and the Printing Press, the Bank and the Corporation. Peace and prosperity had come, at long last, to most parts of Avilund, except some border nations, and, of course, the Crusading Theatres.

It is important to note that despite the modernization of Avilund, contact with the colonies in the Crusading Theatres was not fully established, and in 1510, with the death of Eustace in the Western Theatre, the last contact with the ancient colonies of the Empire was lost permanently. At the time of publication of this volume, it has been 228 years since Men entered either Theatre and returned.

Early History

There are two important regions to consider, when discussing Early History, and this section shall be divided between them; the Eastern Archipelago, and Avilund.

Early History, for Men, occurs exclusively in the Eastern Archipelago, where it is surmised that Men originate from. The only record of any kind about this area is the *Tale of the Woodland King*, which gives us a look at the Archipelago in transition. This tale comes at the end of a presumably long age of strife and turmoil in the Archipelago, though we know little of the source of this trouble. The characters in the *Tale* are the only names we know of this entire region, though before the *Repurgo*, there were many works which gave further light to this region. The First and Second Crusades came back with an abundance of artifacts, documents, history and tales about this region, but none are now to be found anywhere. There is much speculative fiction about this region in this time, but the only hard facts come from the *Tale*, which is just that; a tale.

It is important to note that during this time, the Elders had already prospered and were in their Autumnal Years as a society in Avilund. We know a little of what they had been up to during the time before Men came to Avilund, through the records of the Collegium Waldheim, many of which are preserved by the vigilant keepers of the Seminary of St. Ignatius. It is certain that they were engaged in a war of millennia with the Ferals, and that they had some sort of great inner struggle as well, which was instrumental in their

decline and final ruination. Before Men came to Avilund the Elders had colonized the entire continent, though by the time Men came, many places had been uninhabited for thousands of years, and many were overrun with the Ferals.

Some scholars argue that Early history ends in 201 SHA, when Ignatius, Anselm and Gratus visited Waldheim, and escaped just before its fall to the Ferals, and the destruction of Last Elders of Waldheim. This is an Elderocentric view, which is a valid academic argument, but most credible professors and students of history will acknowledge that Early History ends in 1400 BC, 0 SHA, with the arrival of men in the Elder Dénouement.

Early Middle History

In 1400 BC, the legendary vessel *Bram' Cairn* arrived in Avilund. It departed from an island which was once well known to Men, but today, we do not even know the name of it, or its exact whereabouts. In fact, since the *Repurgo*, there isn't even a useable map of the Archipelago to examine or guess at. However, we do know that Men came from the Eastern Archipelago, and we do know some of the names and deeds of that time. Today, the only document that survives time is the *Tale of the Woodland King*, which is the account of Ignatius, written upon his journey across the sea, about the events of the Prime Saints. This is not a historical document, however. It is just as it advertises; a 'Tale'. However, for over 3000 years it has been commonly accepted as being full of more truths than exaggerations, and numerous other documents about the time before the SHA referenced it with reverence. And so it is today that we accept that the *Tale* is indeed a valuable historical document. Most literate people in Avilund have read this account, and many of those have numerous passages memorized. The clergy of St. Ignatius have, long ago, divided the *Tale* into many numbered passages like some sort of alchemy text, and it is known that they study the Numerology of the *Tale* as its own matter. Much of this cabalistic practice is obscure to even the most enlightened and Saintly of scholars here at Lord's, this author included.

The constituent elements of the *Tale* must herein be discussed briefly, in case the new Student of Humanities has not had the benefit of reading this most ubiquitous of manuscripts. The *Tale* begins, like all Early Literature, with a cosmic display of portent. And in this display, one can see why the faithful of St. Ignatius' began their cabalistic endeavours of numerology. A great meteor shower begins, and it lasts for 11 nights. It pauses for 3 nights, and then goes on for another 11 nights. It is not within the scope of this text to discuss the impact that these opening stanzas of the *Tale* might have had on our Society, but it should be obvious to even the slowest of thinkers that the description of this protracted bout of falling comets is the very root of Cabalistic Numerology, the study of which still causes panic even in this Age of Enlightenment. At the end of the meteor shower, **Avitus** himself is born to a nameless mother. Three years later, his brother **Gaul** is born. The *Tale* describes in some brief but poetic detail the early years of the Prime Saint, Avitus.

Then, the first of the Lessons begins, with the tale of the struggle of Avitus against his brother, Gaul. Gaul, who covets his brother's wife, **Ruth**, plots to take her away. He kills their four children, or at least he thinks he does; **Mairin**, the nursemaid of the children, steals away with the youngest child, **Severinius**, exchanging her own infant son in order to fool Gaul. When the village elders learn that Mairin has fled, and the children of Ruth and Avitus are found dead, it is she that is blamed for the misdeed. This enrages Gaul, who was hoping to frame his brother for the act.

Gaul decides to do something else to ruin his brother's marriage, and next rapes and kills their sister, **Muriel**. This time, he is able to frame his brother for the act, and Avitus is subsequently made a criminal, and forced to flee for his life. Avitus manages to convince his father that he did not do this terrible thing, and goes into hiding while his father travels to the village to clear his name. However, Gaul intercepts his father, and learns of his intent to clear his son's name, and kills the man. Avitus is thus condemned, and he spends the next 33 years wandering in the wilderness. Some theological scholars believe that it is this year that Gaul made his legendary pact with a trio of devils, and that the 3333rd anniversary of this pact will be in 1783 IC.

The *Tale* spends a troubling amount of verse describing the happy relationship that Gaul and Ruth enjoy after the departure of Avitus. Ruth is clearly not the same woman after the tragedies that Gaul inflicted upon her, but Gaul manages to deceive her fully, and she does indeed grow to love him, though she has no children by him (though some theological scholars disagree; this is not within the scope of this volume). Eventually Avitus returns with his son, Severinius and Muriel, who he has found in the wilderness, and made amends with. The three of them confront Ruth, and tell her the truth. Gaul learns that he has been revealed as an evil, plotting murderer, and he flees. Ruth and Avitus are rejoined as husband and wife, and they again conceive. By this time, Severinius has taken over the role of leader on the Island, as Avitus has sworn to hunt to the ends of the earth to find and destroy Gaul.

After some time, Avitus returns home to find that Gaul has returned in his absence and captured Ruth. Gaul is able to take the form of his nephew, Severinius, and manages to capture Avitus thusly. Avitus is bound and forced to watch Gaul rape and murder Ruth, who is quite pregnant at the time. This is too much for Avitus to bear; he breaks his bonds, and the two brothers fight for a period of time (this time is argued by some to be 3 days, by others 33, and 333 by others yet; again, this theological dispute is not suitable for the limited scope of this volume). At any rate, the end result was that Gaul and Avitus destroyed each other and transcended this world; a theological first. These are the first 2 souls to have supposedly entered the Valley of Death, and embarked upon the Journey Beyond Death.

It should be noted here that Ruth has never been Sainted in the PDF. She is assumed to have died too soon for her soul to embark on the Journey. However, though her name has been kept out of the Prime Pantheon, it has not faded into obscurity, though some Prime Saints have. Worship of Ruth is interdictio fides according to the PDF, but despite the best efforts of two inquisitions and other great measures, she continues to issue forth as whispers on the lips of many women.

The bulk of the *Tale* is actually about Severinius. It is Saint Sever that is the *Woodland King* that the title speaks of, and it is his actions and the actions of his contemporaries that are described in the bulk of the *Tale*. Shortly after the transcendence of his father and uncle, Sever brings unification to the warring tribes of the Eastern Archipelago, and is the first Man to be called a King. The *Tale* describes in some length a few important figures; **Ida**, the Angel Messenger that took on a mortal form to wed Sever, and their children **Dunstan**, and **Sebald**. The pantheon of the 11 Prime Saints is further fleshed out in the later parts of the *Tale*, as it illustrates the lives of some contemporaries of the descendants of Avitus discussed above; **Ulric**, the rival and companion of Dunstan, **Caspar** and **Caanan**, the disciples of Severinius, and **Judith**, the wife of Sebald. These names should be familiar to even the least Saintly, save the name of Caanan, who, even to this author, is an enigma. It is not within the scope of this volume to discuss the stories of these individuals, remarkable though they may be. It is just important to know that, in the Modern Age, much of what we know about these Saints can be verified only through examination of this document.

Of course, the *Tale* is the work of **Ignatius**. The life of Ignatius is probably the most sanguineously disputed topic in theology and theological politics today. Through some documents that have survived the *Repurgo*, we know that the origins of Ignatius have been debated ever since the *Contentio Investatus* of 1350 (some scholars are now calling this the *Prima Contentio Investatus*, in light of modern politics which are, again, outside the scope of this volume). The Canon of St. Ignatius has long held that Ignatius was aboard Bram'Cairn when it crossed the Eastern Ocean and arrived on these shores, and that Ignatius interviewed the likes of Dunstan and Sebald during the crossing. This position makes Ignatius long lived indeed, as he is known to have visited Waldheim and met with the Last Elders over 200 years later. There are records of many men living into their hundreds, but few over 200, and those are all descendants of Ida and Sever (Angelspawn). It is a more popular position amongst the Primus Deus Fidelis that Ignatius came to Avilund in a later journey of *Bram'Cairn*, and that he was not in fact a contemporary of Sebald, Dunstan and Barnabas. Others yet argue that Ignatius must have been born and raised in Avilund, and that his clear and haunting depictions of the lands of the Eastern Archipelago are but the product of the mind of a prodigy of literature.

At any rate, a discussion of the life of Ignatius leads us to

Mezzo Middle History

There has been little to no debate over the fact that in 1400 BC, the vessel *Bram'Cairn* arrived in Avilund. The location of its landing is somewhat disputed, though the answer to that question is undeniably hidden in the Valdenwail. To be sure, the ship landed close to the present day location of the Valdenwail, and most certainly within the confines of the Imperial Ecclesiarchy of Valdenwail (IEV). This land was then described as fertile and verdant beyond imagining for the Men of the Islands, though this description does not hold today. By all accounts, the IEV is one of the bleakest places in the quondam Empire today. In those days it was ideally suited for colonization, and it is **Judith**, the wife of Sebald, who is credited with the agricultural taming of those lands. But let us line up some facts as we know them, in order.

1400 BC *Bram'Cairn* arrives in Avilund, with Dunstan, Sebald and Barnabas aboard. Dunstan and Sebald stay in Avilund, and Barnabas returns home as Captain of the ship. This marks the beginning of the *Saeculum Humanitas a Avilund*. It is important to note that Barnabas holds the unique theological position of being a native of the Archipelago, but not a member of the Prime Pantheon. This may well be because of an obstinate tendency towards numerology and the number 11, and therefore a lack of space for him (and Ruth) in the Prime Pantheon. However, some have argued that the origins of Barnabas are uncertain, as they are not detailed in the *Tale*; he is given but a passing reference as the captain of the ship, and nothing more.

1398 BC There was ample documentation before the *Repurgo* that Ulric and a large host of Men from the Islands came and settled Avilund, and from this time forth, migration by ship from the Islands to Avilund persists, for perhaps 100 years or so. This marks the beginning of the *Saeculum Maximus Congrecius*. Sometime after this, Judith, an immigrant from the Islands arrives and marries Sebald. Theirs is the first recorded marriage in Avilund, and their ceremony is very closely followed by the Saintly of both of those Canons today.

1250 BC The first stones of the Valdenwail are laid this year, in order to contain the **Rule of St. Avitus**, which was penned by Sebald. This is the year that is commonly accepted as the formal birth of the Primus Deus Fidelis, as the first PDF document is revealed. Though Sebald is known to have died shortly after this document is revealed, Men experience an unchecked expansion on the continent at this point, for hundreds of years. Agricultural Historians and Natural Scientists suggest that this is largely due to the mastery of farming techniques that Judith had begun, and successful animal husbandry techniques. Certainly, dozens of towns and some small cities spring up from this date forward, and this expansion does not stop for 800 years.

It is important to note that the *Tale* makes no mention of either the Valdenwail, or the Rule of St. Avitus, though it does mark the arrival of Ulric, nearly towards its end. Thus, we can narrow the date of publication of the *Tale* between 1398 BC – 1250 BC. There are scholars who have devoted their entire careers and lives to narrowing this large margin, somewhat, but all in vain. Too little evidence survived the *Repurgo*, and mores the pity.

1206 BC Death of Ulric in the maw of **Razzlethorn**. This beast is described in many tales that have survived the centuries. However, it has been described as everything from a great Dragon, to a huge Spider, and many other things besides. The death of Ulric is significant; he is the last of the Prime Pantheon, and probably the last Archipelago native to draw breath in Avilund. His death is also a sign to the heathen Ferals, who have been held at bay by Ulric and his Knights for decades. With his death, **Vestus the Pestilent** raises a great hoard which marches through the last Elder State, and right up to the walls of Waldheim, beginning a 7 year siege.

1199 BC This is one of the most studied years in Middle History. In this year, the Elder Society is drawing its final breath; the Siege of Vestus seems imminently complete, as the Elder resistance is all but worn down. Ignatius, Anselm and Gratus manage to sneak into the City, and they meet with the Elders for the last time. It is known that Sebald had met the Elders, and that he respected them, and especially, their architecture, which he tried to emulate. However, there are no surviving records detailing any meeting between Sebald or any other Men, and the Elders, and thus the visitation of 1199 BC is significant. These three men, who form an organization known as the **Collegium Waldheim**, spend several weeks with the

last Elders, learning all they can from them. There are entire books and courses of study devoted to this historic last meeting of the Young Race and the Elder, and again, it is not within the scope of this volume to explore this encounter. At the end of the visit, Vestus breaks through the gates, and the time of the Elders is concluded. The Collegium Waldheim manages to escape, fortunately.

It is vital to the understanding of our Culture, that the student of Humanities understands that a seed was planted in the hearts and minds of Men in 1199 BC. The Collegium extolled the virtues and achievements of the Elders, and to this day, Men still perceive themselves as a race that is not only younger than the Elders, but markedly inferior. Much of this complex comes from the deification (later outlawed) of the Elders by Ignatius, Anselm and Gratus, and though it may have left the Men of Avilund feeling somewhat second grade, it compelled an even greater effort of expansion and colonization, and the discovery of all things Elder.

The Collegium is also significant, because it is the first Institute of Learning for Men. Before this time, we had but a crude alphabet and nearly complete illiteracy. After 1199, however, there was a new focus on education and research. Of course, Ignatius, the Saint of Knowledge, Academia and Cartographers, was the father of a variety of disciplines. Gratus, the Saint of Medicine, learned his first Humours from the Elders, and of course, went on to develop medicine in relative leaps and bounds. Anselm is the Saint and Father of New Magic for Men in Avilund, and it was with the Elders in his short visitation that he learned his first cantrip. These men began to study and teach these things to others, though not in the classroom setting that one would imagine today. The study of their academic lives will bring the student of Humanities to appreciate the Modern Age and all of its amenities and comforts in Academia.

Finally, with regards to the Collegium Waldheim, it should be noted that they did indeed have a building, the first school of Men, in fact, in the Valdenwail. We call it the College today, for lack of knowing its true name, if one does indeed exist. For over 2 millennia, this building (of which no description survived the *Repurgo*) was the destination of pilgrimage for the saintly of the three founding Saints and a host of others besides. However, no visitor from outside the superannuated and hermetic walls of the Valdenwail has set foot in the College since 1210.

1099 BC In the hundred years since the fall of Waldheim to the Ferals, Men had made tremendous progress on the continent. There are several large towns and two cities (Tiberwail and Duneedin). Men have pushed back their boundaries significantly, perhaps as far as 200 miles from their stronghold in the Valdenwail. In this year, **Clavo Avitus Vanderwail** (1184-1033 BC), though already known by the title of Scion, declares himself the Emperor of Avilund, and the unification of State and Faith is made fast. Until this time, the leadership of Men had alternated between the two estates, and the towns and villages had their own autonomy and chose governments of their own styling. Indeed, some villages were ruled by heathen councils, still hanging on to the Old Faith of the Archipelago (that which predates the Saintly Faith).

Things were ripe on the continent for this political change. For starters, the ships from the Archipelago had stopped coming to these shores. It is suspected that great wars were ravaging the Archipelago, likely with the Kells deeply involved, or perhaps organized Island Ferals. This is all speculation. What isn't speculation is that the last ship to arrive in the Grey Harbour was the *Cariegh Raeigh*. This ship crashed into the port by either tremendous chance, or Saintly Guidance, for not a living soul walked aboard that vessel, which has become the topic of many an Epic, Romance, and lesser works of fiction since her portentous arrival on these shores. The continental ferals were also in a stage of organization which threatened many of the towns and villages. Many requests for help from the Valdenwail were answered, but only after fealty had been sworn to the Scion.

Though the Scion chose the title of Emperor, he was actually a hereditary king, and his 'Empire' a kingdom, with all the complexities of fealty and vassalage that one can find in the Kingdoms on the continent today. However, by whatever name, the Empire was born, and the Men of Avilund had forged something new and unique to themselves, apart from their island ancestry. And though political semantics can cause interminable debate about the qualities of the 'Empire', doubtless the system worked. By the

time Clavo died in 1033, there were settlements in the northern regions today known as Wellenlund and Isenwald, which are hundreds of miles from the Valdenwail. Siege had been laid to Gulfziam (the Feral name for Waldheim) a number of times, but it was never taken in this time.

450 BC After 650 years of Imperial expansion, the borders of the Empire reached boundaries which they have not crossed even today. Dozens of cities and large towns could be found all over Avilund, and many Elder settlements had been discovered, explored, and resettled. The system of Canon Law had been well established by this time, and the rule of the Vanderwails was absolute, and mostly benign. However, a great threat came in the form of a new hoard of ferals, under the intelligent leadership of **Brogard the Cruel**. Brogard razed dozens of towns and entire provinces of the Empire, including the great city of Tiberwail, which was rebuilt centuries later as Lysander.

By October, Brogard had marched upon the Valdenwail, and indeed laid siege to those inviolable walls. Brogard's was the only army to ever sight the walls of the Imperial City itself. **Lazarus of Duneedin**, then a General of the Imperial Host, put an end to Brogard's rampage. *The Epic of Lazarus of Duneedin*, of which many copies still exist today, tells this tale best. In short, Lazarus first met Brogard in the streets of his native city as it was razed to the ground, and was terribly wounded in the exchange. Though Duneedin was destroyed, Lazarus managed to escape with a couple thousand soldiers and refugees, and retreated to the Valdenwail. There, he rallied his forces and the garrison left at the castle, and managed to hold off the siege of Brogard from October until December. That winter was brutally cold, and Lazarus is credited with the foresight to hold off his counter attack until weeks of bitter cold had taken the edge of his opponents. Outnumbered by over 10:1, Lazarus and his men marched out in the middle of a terrible storm to attack their foes, and Lazarus himself took the head from Brogard, which was the mortal wound of not only Brogard, but of his hoard and rampage. The hoard broke and consumed itself soon afterwards, but in its fragmenting, it continued to cause harm to the every corner of the empire. Indeed, in 435 BC, a group of Ferals who had been raiding a road in the IEV were killed by a group of knights, and they were found to be wearing threadbare tabards from Brogard's personal guard.

Though Brogard's rampage was ended, the Empire, as it had been for over 600 years, had been crippled. The unchecked expansion of Men in Avilund came to an end, and for hundreds of years, there was little communication between the various states of the Empire. Indeed, small feudal kingdoms sprung up again in places that had previously accepted the Imperial Rule. This step backward was born of necessity, as there were no Imperial troops to protect many of these places. The separation of many of these states from not only the Imperial Rule, but of the Canonical Rule was bitter and lasting; in Mantlethorn and Hiergallad never fully recovered from the hardships of the years to follow, and during the Second Age of Imperial Expansion, these two regions never fully accepted the Primogeniture of the Scion, and during the *Repurgo*, these Kingdoms were instrumental in bringing about the end of the Rule of the Scion.

Late Middle History

This is one of the most commonly accepted periods of history; it is sharply defined by the year 450 BC, with the destruction of Brogard's hoard at the outset, and the conquest of Gulfziam by Abaddon at its termination. This age goes by many names; Twilight Ages, Age of Rebuilding, Age of Sorrow, Age of Fragmentation, and many others besides.

During this period of History, Men in Avilund struggled to reclaim the territories lost to the invasion of Brogard. While things in the south of the Empire progressed smoothly, in the middle-continent and the north, it was more difficult. These states were farther from Imperial support, and Feral populations had been historically larger and more troublesome in those territories as well. In the north, reclaiming the Imperial territories was further hindered by the arrival, in 244 BC of the Kells.

The arrival of the Kells in 244 BC is well documented. They arrived in a great fleet of hundreds of oar- and sail-drawn rakers from the Eastern waters, with a host of perhaps some tens of thousands. They landed north of Hiergallad, and have troubled that kingdom ever since. The Kells were met immediately with force by the Knights of Hiergallad, who, despite having great numbers and the advantage of a defensive

position, were not prepared for the ferocity of the Kells, who fought in an unordered and completely different manner than the Knights were prepared for. Their savagery in battle made even the Continental Ferals look civilized by comparison. It is difficult to say how things might have been different, if the King of Heirgallad had extended the olive branch rather than the sword, but perhaps the Empire might have found a new ally. The Kells never seemed more than mildly interested in the lands south of Hiergallad, and have only ever attacked peripheral towns and villages of that Kingdom since their arrival 2000 years ago. Indeed, the Kells seemed more interested in the coastal areas north of the Imperial borders, and likely fought countless more battles with the Ferals than with Men.

Though the Kells were (and are) terribly vicious opponents when provoked, they actually preferred (and still do) to settle land and property disputes with one-on-one combat with champions. Once the King of Heirgallad learned of this tradition in the Kells, he quickly embraced the custom, which was not too far removed from the Right of Challenge which the knights and other nobility of Heirgallad and other kingdoms already practiced. Unfortunately, it took until the year 105 BC before King Garamond of Heirgallad figured this out, and the countryside of the Kingdom was a place of constant war for those intervening years. However, in 105 BC, King Garamond held council with the Kellish Warlord Raighth, over a land dispute on the edge of the kingdom. They decided to settle it themselves, by having their champions fight to the death to determine the outcome. Fighting for Garamond was Edgar Steadholme, a knight of great renown. For Raighth, a barbarian named Klunaigh took the field. Songs of this battle are still sung on both sides of the Kell/Heirgallad border to this day. It was an epic affair of some hours, in which the two killed a great many spectators with their dervish-like melee. Indeed, King Garamond was struck on the hand and lost 3 fingers by the blade of his own Champion, and Raighth's son was slain by the thrown axe of his. Despite the collateral injuries, the terms of the dispute were held, and it did not escalate into a free-for-all, though the songs do intone that any lesser Men would have let it devolve. In the end, both Champions killed each other, and the province was declared a neutral ground, on which a great lodge has stood ever since. This battle brought relative peace to the region, and an understanding between those two peoples. Even today, it is not unheard of for challenges to be issued from either side of the border for a duel of champions. Peace there was not absolute though; small scale raiding and skirmishing lasted there for centuries to come.

The story of the battle of Klunaigh and Steadholme is typical of the age. This was an age of fighting and war, and most stories that have survived this time are those of heroic deeds of battle. Many Saints emerged in this heroic time, but one must not get the impression that life was all fighting and glory. In fact, life for almost all people of Avilund was typified by hunger, fear and doubt. That a few brave souls could rise above the pervading squalor and famine of this age to fight the heroic battles for which the age is mostly associated with is worth mentioning, but it should not be confused for the standard of life then.

Towards the edge of this age, Abaddon of Ezlonia was born to a relatively wealthy noble family in Mantlethorn. He became a Knight in the Order of Ulric by the time he was 18, and was an accomplished hero of many battles by the age of 20. He earned his laurels fighting the Kells in the north, but it wasn't long before he was called to a higher duty; in the service of his order (and, no doubt, pursuing his own family interest) in the north. A group of Collegium scholars and a priest of St. Ignatius put the idea in Abaddon's head that it would be the noblest of ventures to take the city of Gulfziam (Waldheim) from the Ferals, and he began his own personal campaign to liberate the City. Abaddon laid siege to the City no less than 13 times in as many years, and actually set foot on its hallowed streets a number of times before his final liberation of the City. The life of Abaddon and his conquest of Waldheim is the focus of study for many scholars and historians, and shall not be expanded further within these pages. The author refers the reader to the Holy Repository of the Canon of St. Abaddon in Waldheim, where the deeds of this Saint have been more than adequately recorded and preserved. The conquest of Waldheim begins the two commonly-discussed historical periods; the **Saeculum Dominae Humanitas a Avilund**, which persists to this day, and the **Saeculum Imperiosus Luxamentum Secundus**, or the Second Age of Imperial Expansion.

Late History

With the conquest of Walheim by Abaddon, historians mark the beginning of the Late Period. Late History is a time that is most associated with the slow expansions and contractions of the Empire, as it tries to expand into the Holy Theatres, and struggles with a new-found enemy. It is in Late History that the scholar will first read of the 'Black Faith', and witness the erosion of the Society of Man from the inside, which made his expansion and dominion difficult. Late History is divided into 3 commonly accepted periods; Early Late History (0 to 750), Middle Late History (750 to 1348), and Modern History (1348 to present).

Early Late History

Before the *Repurgo*, this was the most widely studied period of History. This period is marked by the great migration of Men of the Empire into the Holy Theatres, known as the Crusades, and the unearthing, study, and development of the Magic of the Elders (called "New Magic" by Scholars of the Arcane; this age is sometimes called the Age of New Magic by practitioners of the Art). During this period, the Scion sits as Emperor in the City of Abaddon (the name given to Gulfziam after Abaddon's conquest, by the not-so-humble conqueror himself), and has dominion over all the lands from Lyasander and the Valdenwail, to Heirgallad in the far North. With the excavations of the Elder Cities, Men learn road and bridge improvements that allow for a vast infrastructure for the Empire which makes the transporting of troops, supplies, goods and information quicker, safer and more efficient than had previously been imagined by the fearful Men of the Dark Ages. This is a tumultuous time, but also a time of great expansions of the Empire, and the furtherance of the Society of Men in Avilund. Some of the important dates of this age are listed, below;

- 0 Excavation of the Valde Aula Waldheim by the Society of St. Ignatius
- 244-248 The Armed Pilgrimage (First Crusade) to the Eastern Theatre
- 334-518 Pilgrimage of the Pilgrims of Vander (Second Crusade) to the Eastern Theatre
- 548-594 Pilgrimage of the Ordo Croceus Cervus (Third Crusade) to the Western Theatre
- 528 Massacre at St. Irenaeus
- 639 Massacre at Tarmin
- 750 Massacre at the Cathedral of St. Avitus, Waldheim, Black Faith unmasked.

One of the greatest archaeological finds of all time is the Valde Aula Waldheim; the Great Hall of the Elders. The hall was unearthed by the Scholars and Priests of St. Ignatius that had motivated and followed around Abaddon for twenty years. The Hall would have been a find of the first order if nothing but the floor was found; for upon the floor was a map of the Elder Civilization on the Continent. This map was used to locate dozens of other ruins. The Hall was also full of a great deal of Elder History in the form of carved friezes and statuary. This find was instrumental in the development of New Magic, as one of the ruins later uncovered provided most of the materials Men needed to further their study of the Magic of the Elders, and lead to a proliferation of practitioners of magic and artifacts. This find also secured the fiscal and political strength of the Canon of St. Ignatius, which it still enjoys to this day.

As the roads of the Empire became safer, and her borders more secure, it wasn't long in this age before Men started to look beyond their borders. By 244, **Scion Innocentus** (198-281) inspired a great movement known as the Armed Pilgrimage, after his Oratory of Faith, on July 1, 244, in the Blue Square of Abaddon. Emissaries of the Scion traveled throughout the Empire inciting the Clergy and Nobility to arms, and by September of 245, a host of men and ships which had not been seen since the *Saeculum Maximus Congrecius* was assembled in the Bay of St. Barnabas, and they departed before the winter storms that year for the Eastern Archipelago, to locate, pacify and colonize the Holy Birthplace of St. Avitus. By all surviving accounts, they did indeed locate the archipelago, and established the first colonies there, but contact with those colonies (and Scion Innocentus, who had traveled to the home of his ancestors) was lost in 281, and would not be reestablished for decades.

In 333, an auspicious year for the superstitious people of this age, a timely meteor shower in November persisted for 11 days and threw the Empire into chaos. Many feared that the time of Men was about to end. However, a clever Scion, **Lothar the Unifier** (301-389) claimed to have been visited in his sleep by St. Avitus. His ancestor, he claims, explained off the meteor shower as a great host of Angels that had flown

from Heaven into Hell to wage war, and that the time had come to emulate the deeds of Angels here on Earth. He promptly changed the name of the city of Abaddon to St. Avitus (a name which is still used by many of the staunch canons of the PDF), and many other places besides, in order to inflate the currency and façade of power of the Empire and the Canon of St. Avitus.

For all the transparencies in his strategy to unify the panicked and fragmenting Empire, it worked. On December 7, 333, **Luke of Abaddon**, the patriarch of the **Ulmar Family**, mobilized the entire resources of his Family, and much of the military strength of the Canon of St. Ulric, of which he was a senior clergyman, pledging to serve the Scion in whatever capacity the Scion might choose. Luke had been to the Eastern Archipelago in his youth, and had fought many battles against the ferals on land, and against the Kells at sea. By the spring of 334, there were again hundreds of nobles and clergymen from a number of families and many of the militant canons assembled in the Bay of St. Barnabas. They had all been inculcated into a new Order; the **Pilgrims of Vander**, which still exists in some small capacity in Lysander today. Then, as now, The Pilgrims of Vander were answerable ultimately to the Scion, with a High Marshal (Luke was the first) leading them. They were given a charter by the Scion, and granted lands in many parts of the Continental Empire, as well as promises of lands in the Holy Archipelago. Instrumental to the success of this second 'Crusade' was the shortage of land in the Empire worth fighting for. It is speculated that the number of nobles in the Empire was at its historical zenith in that very year of 334, and second-sons and lesser nobles were likely enticed by the promise of lands of their own in the Theatre, if only they fought.

The fleet took the entire Summer and Autumn to finally assemble, but by late October of 334, 50,000 men pledged to serve the Scion and follow the High Marshall into the Theatre. Before the *Repurgo*, this Crusade was studied in-depth as its own matter by scores of Historians. While some few literary works detailing this Crusade have survived, there were thousands of books and maps detailing every aspect of this Crusade before the fires of David of Sandalstone sought them out. The criminals of the *Repurgo* seemed to seek out works about this Crusade in particular, and took every measure and risk to destroy the hundreds of maps that had recorded the details of this crusade.

Fortunately, in recent years a few texts have been uncovered, though no maps, regarding this Crusade. The numbers of men partaking in this event is well documented in more than one source, but references to 'The Great Album', suggest that a complete roster was made of every man and horse that set foot on one of the boats of the fleet. It is well documented that King Gamaliel of Heirgallad, and King Tomas of Mantlethorn boarded the boats themselves with over 1000 men each. There were many Prelates and Arch Bishops amongst the men, with Golgatha, Prelate of the Canon of St. Ulric acting as the spiritual head of the expedition, and second-in-command.

On October 19, 334 the fleet departed. In late Spring of the following year, news of it's great success started to sail back to the Empire, and further fueled the Crusade. A second wave of ships and men departed in 335 for the Archipelago. Today, it is uncertain how many colonies were reestablished, and how many new ones were founded, but it is certain there were many. For nearly 200 years, men choked the docks of St. Barnabas to get on board any ship heading to the East, for a chance at prospering from the adventurous activities of this Crusade. Indeed, many ships returned laden with great wealth, and tales about the Pilgrims of Vander and their vast success abounded. However, something else came back with the ships along with wealth; tales of a strange religion practiced by the inhabitants of the old colonies of the first Crusade, and even stranger tales of what had become of the survivors in those colonies in the years between the Crusades.

Although details about the events leading up the end of the Second Crusade are now sketchy, again because of the effects of the *Repurgo*, it is known that rival Crusader Kingdoms came to war in the Theatre. By 516, war in the Archipelago was raging, and opportunistic ferals and Kells also joined the chaos. In the winter of 517, fleets of people fleeing from the madness that had become the Theatre came into St. Barnabas like so many scolded dogs. In 518, the Scion managed to assemble a host of some 15,000 men to pacify the region anew, but this fleet was never heard from again, and so it is that the Second Crusade comes to an end in that year.

In the years between 518 and 548, the Empire experienced a dramatic increase in atrocious crimes in her cities and towns that were uncommon before this time. Ritual killings and massacres became a common occurrence, and many people went missing from areas that were previously considered safe, such as the civilized cities of the Monastic South and in St. Avitus itself. Though some historians draw a connection to the demographic crisis of those years, with so many able-bodied men having vanished over the seas in the first half of the 4th century, it is doubtless that the Black Faith was beginning to take hold in Avilund, its poison starting to course through the veins of Empire.

By 548, crimes of this sort, and crime and chaos in general were endemic in the Empire. There were too few nobles and senior clergy remaining after the failed Second Crusade to deal with all the problems at home, and for the first time in its history, the Empire found itself dealing with the problem of incarceration. There were too many criminals to house and manage reasonably, and while there were many proposals for dealing out harsher punishments for lesser crimes (hanging for just about everything), this solution was just not palatable for the people of this time. The Scion of the time, **Malregard Avitus Vanderwail** (389-568), was enterprising and resourceful like his father, Lothar. Like his father before him, he was visited in his sleep by his great ancestor, St. Avitus, who claimed that a safer rout to the Holy Archipelago could be found by going overland through the West, rather than heading East in boats in what had become a perilous time for navigation. Malregard claimed that in the dream, St. Avitus had a golden stag at his side, and behind the stag were many Saints. The Scion promptly ordered the creation of the **Ordo Croceus Cervus** (Order of the Golden Stag), and declared the pilgrimage through the Western Theatre in his famous, publicly delivered oratory and declaration of the **Occasus Bellum Via**, on August 29, 548.

At this point in History something new happens in the Ecclesiastic Empire of Men. The Pilgrims of Vander, which at this point in history are headquartered in the town of St. Barnabus, announce that they would not follow the orders of the Scion, largely because of the refusal of the Prelate of Ulric to comply with the conditions of the pilgrimage. It is not difficult to imagine that the High Marshal of the order and the Prelate of St. Ulric would have been nonplussed at the appointment of a new order to carry out what had been their business for the last two hundred years. But there was an even larger problem; Malregard declared in his oration that the time had come to create the **Magnus Collego Sanctus**, a great collection of the Saintly Artifacts from all of the Canons, to be kept in the Valdenwail, in order to secure them against the uncertainty of the time, and to safeguard them while the fighting orders were away from home. The Ordo Croceus Cervus would be charged with protecting this reliquary for all times. This did not sit well with the Prelates of many canons, St. Ulric none-the-least. The Prelate refused to surrender Salm, Ulrics battleaxe, as well as the other artifacts of the Canon, and other Prelates followed his lead. This was the first recorded schism of the PDF, the first act of non-compliance by any Prelate.

It is suspected that the Scion created some sort of secret order or agency that was charged with the procurement, by any means possible, of all the Saintly Artifacts in Avilund. Several smaller Canons that refused to submit to the terms of the Scion did have their artifacts go missing. However, there was never any known documentation of proof that the Scion had a hand in this, and to be sure, there was a growing preponderance of the Black Faith in those times that might have had the same larcenous goal.

The Ordo Croceus Cervus was gearing up for their march along the Occasus Bellum Via, and many of the less-seditious canons backed this Crusade and the Order that was leading it. This is the Crusade of Saint Severinius, whose Canon was chosen to back the Ordo, and see to the spiritual well-being of the pilgrims. The body of St. Sever was relocated to the Magnus Collego Sanctus in a great ceremony in November of 548, and interred in the Collego, and the Mace of the Ordo Croceus Cervus was bestowed upon the Prelate of St. Sever by the Scion himself on that day in the Valdenwail.

Religious and political tensions in the Empire were at a zenith in 549; the problems of crime and criminals had not lessened, and more than half of the Saintly Canons followed the lead of the Canon of St. Ulric, and refused to surrender their artifacts to the Scion and his reliquary. The Prelate of St. Sever, no doubt acting under the direct orders of the Scion, declared that any Canon that did not submit its artifacts to the reliquary could not partake in the Pilgrimage along the Occasus Bellum Via. This caused great pressures for the noncompliant Canons; it was suspected that this organized march into the West would be the first great opportunity to safely secure lands west of the Sea of Sorrow and the Devils Plain, and they sorely wanted

to be involved. To make matters worse, artifacts continued to be stolen from the smaller Canons, and some Canons actually lost their Holy Writ from the Scion because of this. To this day, it is still Canonical Law that a Faith can only maintain its Writ so long as it can provide physical evidence of the Sanctus Mortuis Some of the Saint in question. Despite the fact that there are no known surviving artifacts some of the larger faiths, such as that of Judith and Sebald, the PDF was still able to wield this rule selectively, and apply pressure on some Canons that were poised to lose Writ. The Canon of **St. Theobald**, for example, was given the chance to maintain Writ after the body of their Saint was stolen, by declaring that they would submit all their holdings in the Western Theatre to the Vanderwails. This was a common agreement that kept several Canons alive.

This all seems like a more protracted explanation for background events for the Third Crusade, but it is important to understand the religious and political tensions of the time, to understand what happened next. Late in June of 549, the Scion and the Ordo Croceus Cervus were getting anxious to get the pilgrimage under way, but they were having a difficult time assembling what they thought was a suitable expeditionary force without the inclusion of the Canon of St. Ulric and the backing of the Pilgrims of Vander. Those Historians that give Malregard a generous degree of credit claim that he foresaw the difficulties and the slight schism of the PDF, and knew that those who would remain loyal to him would be of insufficient numbers to mount a proper pilgrimage. As the season grew late and the small army of the Ordo became a greater burden upon the City of Lysander, the staging point for the pilgrimage, the pressure to assemble the needed men and get things underway became severe. At this point, Malregard penned the **Propositum Servitus**, which declared that any criminal who served under the banner of the Golden Stag for one year in the Western Theatre would be a free man at the end of that service, and be entitled to lands in the Theatre. And so in one stroke of the pen, two great problems were solved; the jails were emptied all over the Empire, and a suitable host was assembled in Lysander by the end of September. It is worth noting that this mobilization happened much faster than logistically possible for the time, and it is doubtless that this measure was planned out in great detail long before the Propositum was put to paper and made legal.

While the problem of bolstering the crusading expedition had been solved, there still remained the religio-political problem of the Collego, and the sedition of the Canons to deal with. The Scion was worried, and rightly so, that once the armies of his loyal subjects were thousands of miles away in the Western Theatre, that the influence of those that stayed home, Ulric and Ignatius in particular, would become too potent. Malregard devised a plan that might have worked, if not for a protracted bout of terrible luck much later on, and the unforeseen deviousness of some Prelates. He knew that the Prelate of St. Ulric desperately wanted to join the Pilgrimage, as it would certainly be a lucrative venture, and that crusading is at its core the essence of the Canon of St. Ulric. Malregard offered an amendment to his demands upon the PDF to submit their artifacts to the Collego; he declared that any Canon that would bring its artifacts to bear in the Western Theatre could retain them afterwards, and that any Canon losing Sanctus Mortuis Some as a result of the pilgrimage would not lose Writ. This declaration brought the Canon of St. Ulric and many others (though not St. Ignatius) into the Pilgrimage, and also assembled the greatest number of religious artifacts ever gathered together.

Finally, on 3 December, 549, the host marched from Lysander and into the Western Theatre, with more than 100,000 men, half of which were criminals under the banner of the Golden Stag. This was a slow and deliberate Crusade. The veteran campaigners of the Pilgrims of Vander insisted on a forced march through the desert and into whatever lands were to be found beyond, but the Ordo took a different approach. They built fortress after fortress on the long march of decades into the Western Theatre, and was this decision to do so that won them the prosperity that they still enjoy to this day. In the Western Theater, the Men of the Empire found Men of a different variety; the dusky skinned Foreigners, or Westerners, that we know of today. They found many new races and tribes of ferals as well, and between these two new opponents, a forced march could not be maintained. Logistics in the face of a pair of relentless foes would have been impossible, if not for the deliberate fortifying approach of the Ordo. This approach also secured the new road for decades during this Crusade and the later, Fourth Crusade, and many villages and small kingdoms grew out from the walls of the Crusader Castles that line the Bellum Via.

For the next 45 years, the Pilgrimage in the Western Theatre continued, and every summer news would come back from the front of new fortresses built, new kingdoms of westerners defeated, new races of ferals

destroyed, new treasures raided and riches flowing back east. And so, every autumn, new recruits headed west along the Bellum Via into the Western Theatre. The Ordo Croceus Cervus became more rich and powerful than the Pilgrims of Vander, and the authority and influence of the Canon of St. Sever reached its height at the end of this Crusade.

By 590, however, things started to change. After more than 40 years of marching westward, there was some doubt about the existence of a passage to the Eastern Theatre, and so the confidence of the pilgrimage was shaken. As well, by this time the pilgrims had met with a very strong kingdom of Westerners which they could make any progress past, let alone conquer. The name of this kingdom is now lost to History, but certainly it must have been spoken in curses for centuries to follow, as it was this kingdom which put an end to the Third Crusade, and in fact mobilized its own crusade, of a stamp, against the Men of the Empire.

In 591, news came back to Lysander that several castles on the front had been destroyed, with entire garrisons massacred. The Crusade had ceased its dauntless progress westward, and fewer people flocked to its cause that Autumn. In 592, heretical news arrived that the front had moved eastward by more than 500 miles, and that many castles were surrendering to the Westerners, and, worse yet, converting to their faith. While there was a brief redoubling of Imperial efforts to fortify the front and cease the loosing of ground to the heathen Westerners, by 593 the front had moved back more than 1000 miles total. The loss of ground and castles in this year was concomitant with the loss of several Holy Artifacts and relics. Several of the artifacts of the Canon of St. Ulric were lost in monumental battles, and those of other Canons vanished in a variety of ways. While there were many rumours about Scions secret order operating in the Western Theatre stealing artifacts for the Collego, doubtless many were lost honestly in the ceaseless advance of the Westerners and their conquest over the Crusader Castles.

In 594 a host of some 7,000 men of both Crusading Orders were assembled in Lysander. They marched off in August, but by October, the van of the heathen crusading army approached the walls of St. Severinius Castle on the Bellum Via bearing grisly evidence of the annihilation of the OCC and PV army that had marched westward 2 months earlier. A siege of the castle ensued, but only briefly. By the time December came, the Western army lifted siege and departed, but the will of the Empire to make pilgrimage in the Western Theatre had been destroyed, and it would be over 800 years before an organized effort to make pilgrimage westward again was made.

This age is associated with the unmasking of the Black Faith as well as the Crusades. In the monastery of St. Irenaeus in 528, a plot to murder the Saintly folk there was uncovered. A warden of the monastery named **Ultan** was found to be practicing some very unorthodox rituals, and he was subsequently arrested, tried and sentenced to death. He was sentenced to hang, but made a full confession and renounced his obscene faith, and requested that he be drowned in the well rather than hang, stating that he did not want his death to become a spectacle that might draw others into the cult into which he had been inculcated. He was thrown in the well with weights around his ankles and drowned. On the Feast of All Hallow's Eve, several months later, all of the residents of the monastery were poisoned by the water from the well, and before midnight the entire population of over 1000 was dead. The bodies were not discovered until the next spring when merchants arrived to trade, and they reported that the bodies had been laid out in a corn field in a specific fashion to spell the name of 'Ultan'. This was the first recorded encounter with this name, and it is not known if the man known as Ultan was possessed by the Devil of the same name, or if he simply affected that name, or if the soul of the man ascended to become the Devil that many theologians are now familiar with.

In 639 the village of Tarmin in the Bishopric of St. Sebald, nearby to Lysander, learned the terrible name of **Sodor**. By this time, the Third Crusade was well over, and the demographic recovery of the Empire had begun. Though the wealth associated with the Crusades had ceased to flow down the Bellum Via, the Empire was making an economic recovery after the blow dealt to it in 594. After 40 years, there was again optimism. However, this was jilted when in the autumn of 639 when traders came to the village and found it completely annihilated. There wasn't a living soul in the village, and the corpses of some 1000 villagers had been mutilated beyond recognition. In fact, the faces of all the villagers had been removed and used to make a gigantic and grisly mosaic which depicted a four-armed devil of some sort. On the doors of every dwelling the name "Sodor" was found scrawled in blood. It is likely that after this occurrence, or possibly

even the massacre at St. Irenaeus, that the Scion instituted the Inquisition, but it was not unmasked quite yet.

111 years after the massacre at Tarmin, the Black Faith struck it's most terrible blow to date. In the Autumn of 750, the PDF was sitting conclave in Waldheim. At a large banquet in the Cathedral of St. Avitus, the plotting of the Black Faith was revealed in a well-timed and well-planned out attack upon the Cathedral. Members of the Black Faith had infiltrated many of the Canons that were invited to the banquet, including St. Sever, St. Sebald and St. Ignatius. It was the multitudinous servants of evil in the ranks of the Ignatians that has helped to keep that faith in poor standing in the PDF to this very day. When the high-ranking officials of all the guest-canons were seated, knives were drawn, and terrible magics wielded, and the banquet-hall turned into an abattoir. At the same time, terrible monstrous demons assailed the guard on the streets, keeping them from helping their doomed masters inside. The Scion, **Nicetus Avitus Vanderwail** (700-804) was himself attacked in that bloody banquet, but was able to make his escape with a few of his closest advisors through the virtue of his own great will, or so the stories go. At the end of the night, hundreds of clergy from many canons lay dead and mutilated, the Prelates of St. Ignatius and St. Sebald included. This event remains the most heinous assassination ever successfully carried out in the PDF. When order was restored, the culprits had vanished, but had hung a great banner over the banners of the Scion and the Empire which declared the Avilund belonged to '**Maccul**' and his 'Black Saints'. Thus all three names of the devils had made their debut, their suspected leader last, and his 'Black Saints' announced. This had the intended effect; panic spread throughout the Empire like a fire in a dry plain.

There are more than a few heretical accounts of those days that suggest that Emperor Nicetus had much to gain through the deaths of the Prelates of St. Ignatius and St. Sebald, as well as many other political figures who perished at the banquet. It is theorized that the Scion had proposed the institution of the Inquisition at the previous Conclave, but the motion was turned down largely through the influence of the Ignatians. Further, it was uncommon in those days for any Canon but those of the First Order to be invited to the Banquet of the Scion, and St. Ignatius alone of the Second Order was invited. Unfortunately, any records that might shed light on this possible conspiracy, heresy though it may be, have never been mentioned. Three nights after the massacre, Nicetus began the terrible age of Inquisition when he made his infamous decree, the **Prospectus Imperialis ex Daemonica**.

Middle Late History

On November 23, 750, as the blood was still being washed from the Cathedral in Waldheim, Nicetus delivered his terrible and heavy handed decree from the Emperors Balcony in the Blue Palace. The face of Nicetus as it withdrew from that balcony after his oration was the last face of any Scion to be seen in public again. They have lived in seclusion ever since the massacre at the cathedral, and none have delivered a public oration since that time. The **Prospectus Imperialis ex Daemonica** was designed to counter the Black Faith, which was seemingly growing in influence and power. That the servants of Maccul could infiltrate the higher ranks of some of the more powerful Canons was worrisome, and thus harsh measures were called for. Inquisitors began to stalk the lands and the cities, and their power was absolute. The birth of the **Prospectus** marks the beginning of the long estrangement of the Canons of the Collegium from the main Sainly Faith. It was their Canons that suffered the most from the Inquisition, for it targeted men of learning and magic specifically.

With the Inquisition set loose upon the Empire, the faiths of the Collegium were greatly reduced in power. Their clergy men were afraid to practice their learned professions, and society as a whole suffered. Records from this period were few even before the *Repurgo*, and are all but extinct today. Despite the efforts of the Inquisition, the Black Faith grew, and their crimes became more ubiquitous and heinous. With every crime or perceived crime of the Black Faith, another Inquisitor was given his letter of marque, and set loose upon the Empire. So it was that the Empire came to have two enemies gnawing at its insides, and so it was that it began to shrink. The Imperial Army was conscripted by the Inquisitors to do their bidding, and were thus unable to do their duties at the borders effectively. The infrastructure was seriously damaged by the in Inquisition as well, as too many farmers and other providers were put to the torch, the water or the noose to generate the surpluses needed to feed the Empire.

The Scion was ever suspicious of the faiths of the Collegium, and as the Inquisition grew in power, many people turned to those faiths for sanctuary. This actually caused a brief period of expansion for these three faiths, and new abbeys were founded in regions that were previously closed to them. The Inquisition was quick to show up in these areas and make life difficult for the clergy and the lay people of these villages. The only limitation the inquisition had to deal with in those days was the Law of Sanctuary, which prevented them from entering any holy place without permission by the senior clergy there. However, in 889, Scion **Tancred Avitus Vanderwail** (804-1009) penned the **Prospectus ex Veneficium**, which not only put an end to that sole limitation of the Inquisition, but it also made the study and practice of any magic other than the Divine, a crime punishable by death. As one could well imagine, this was not well received by the Canon of St. Anselm, and the other Canons of the Collegium backed their ally. All their defiance of the Prospectus earned them were visitations by irate and vengeful Inquisitors. With the implementation of the new Prospectus, learned men mark the beginning of the **Saeculum Noctis Obscuris**, in which the spread of learning, magic and medicine was completely halted, and practitioners of these professions were forced into hiding. Indeed, many faithful clergy of the faiths of the Collegium were put to death by the ubiquitous Inquisitors, and the divide between these formerly powerful Canons and the Scion and his allies was made broader and deeper.

There is little good that can be said about this age. Imperial citizens were burned, hanged and drown by the hundreds, and the though the death toll can never be accurately figured (outside the walls of the Valdenwail or Dimmantle), it is likely that over one million citizens lost their lives. There would certainly have been many practitioners of the Black Faith amongst them, but certainly not one in one-hundred.

By 1019, the Empire was in jeopardy of collapsing completely. There were no longer enough people left to feed the big cities, and famine and disease became rampant in these places. The city of Avitus (Waldheim) endured a long plague that killed 2 people in 5, and in Lysander, there was enough famine to cause riots in what is normally the most well-governed and disciplined people of the Empire.

In the North, things happened that caused all of this to change. The Kingdom of Heirgallad had suffered the Inquisition so badly that it had not a single farmer left to feed what was left of the Kingdom. The entire Kingdom was but a single winter from starvation and extinction. At this time, a great host of Kells marched upon Castle Heirgallad, and when King Armund of Heirgallad rode out to meet the King of the Kells to find his terms, it is said that the Kell stroked the emaciated flank of the horse, shook his rivals weak hand, and wept. He turned his army about immediately, and left his dying enemy alone for the rest of that century.

News of this encounter reached Mantlethorn. Though the two northern Kingdoms had been on-again off-again allies and enemies, King Aeginthorn showed his quality by declaring a lasting piece with his neighbour, and provided what little assistance his people could to see them through the winter. Aeginthorn and Armund gathered what nobles and men-at-arms they had remaining, and they rode to Avitus, where they delivered a Declaration of Succession at the Blue Palace. They were quickly arrested in the Palace, many of their nobles and men killed almost immediately by the overzealous Inquisitors who watched over the proceedings there. However, the Steward of the Blue Palace ordered the Inquisitors to stand down and to unhand the two kings and their men. They were kept as 'guests' in the palace for several months, while word of this was brought to the Scion in the Valdenwail. The Scion of the Time, **Maiolus the Forgiving, Maiolus Avitus Vanderwail** (1009-1210), heard the story of the Kings, and it is rumoured that he too wept at the story of the Kells, and how the men of the north would rather come to their certain death in the Blue Palace, than live under the Crimson Banner of the Empire. He immediately ordered all Inquisitors out of the Northern Provinces, and sent aid there to make amends. This was the first stroke against the First Inquisition.

The second and fatal stroke would fall in Hamstonfast in the Bishopric of St. Ignatius in October of 2021. The infamous Inquisitor Kerrigan came to this village and put all 900 of its citizens to death during his investigation there, including his own retinue. When word of this reached Maiolus, he immediately put an end to Inquisitorial Authority, and had many Inquisitors themselves tried in the Valdenwail, where their fates became unknown and lost to those lonely halls. Though the Inquisition was formally ended in

December of 1021, it was several years before all of the Inquisitors in the field were rounded up and called home, and their barbarous atrocities endured, though in a much-reduced fashion.

What followed was not a rebirth of Learning, Magic and Medicine. The citizens of the Empire were forever scarred by the Inquisition, and still feared to do anything they would have done during the bloody years of the Prosepecti. Unfortunately, the Empire still stayed curled up inside itself, afraid to once again stand and stretch, so effective were the Inquisitors of the Scion in their dreadful duty.

Almost 200 years past between the end of the Inquisition and the *Repurgo Imperialis*. Little happened in those between years; the Empire was stagnant, and there were some small internecine conflicts over scarce resources, though nothing on a scale worth mentioning in this short historic survey.

However, in 1210, the Casparian Monk **David of Sandalstone** arrives on the set of History. He had taken the Rule of St. Caspaar into a perverted context which suggested that all learning and records were heresy and an affront to St. Avitus and the Saintly Faith. His misinterpretation of the Rule could not have been planted in more fertile soil. Though the rivers of blood and mountains of corpses left behind by the First Inquisition had vanished over the previous 200 years, their memory was fresh, and the terror they left behind just as sharp and clear as it was when Kerrigan walked in Avilund. Adding to this was the fact that society had not been much improved by the end of the Inquisition, which was largely blamed on the Black Faith, and those who supported it. The list of Black Faith supporters was of varying length, depending on what region one takes into account, and the level of education of the interpreter. However, it was not difficult to convince the simple folk of those unenlightened days that the Clerk or the Money Lender to which they were heavily indebted had much to do with the Black Faith. David had a natural talent for identifying enmity in a new village, and was quick to orate to the poor masses and turn them against the objects of their enmity. By 1212, the Casparians were in every province of the Empire, setting entire libraries and schools to the torch, and stringing up those learned men which they perceived to be members of the Black Faith. Just about every one who could read was a target of the Casparians, and in this time, having followed a long and bloody period of purgation of the educated elite, the illiterate were legion, an angry and armed legion. The *Repurgo* seemed especially focused on destroying such things as maps and instruments and records of navigation. So it was that the Canon of St. Caspaar and St. Ignatius came to an irreconcilable conflict which persists to this day. This conflict is the first open non-secular internecine conflict of the Saintly Faith, and it was this conflict that drew the attention of the Scion.

The fires of St. Caspaar outlived David by a century, but the drive and hatred he held was found in countless Caspaarians in the decades following his death in 1248. By 1295, the Prelate of St. Caspaar, **Eugene of St. Caspaar**, declared an open war on the Canon of St. Ignatius. This declaration was illegal as per the Rule of St. Sever, and so the Scion, **Baudri Avitus Vanderwail** (1210-1350) became involved. He publicly denounced the declaration of war, stating that Eugene did not have the Saintly Authority to order it, but he took no further actions himself. Rather, he reinstituted the Inquisition, and again, the lights in the unsleeping towers of Dimmantle light up, and riders issued forth. It is certain that the Emperor was suspicious of the actions and motivations of the Caspaarians, and it is also certain that elements of the Black Faith had been heavily involved with this Canon from the start of the *Repurgo* in 1210. It is often rumoured that David himself was likely possessed, but this can in no way now be verified.

It is important to understand that a change in the power structure of the Empire had taken hold in the years since the end of the First Inquisition. The Saintly Faith had lost some currency as a protector of the people, and the societal ideal we know today as the Feudal Kingdom was entrenched. In the Northern provinces especially, people began to pledge themselves to a landed and powerful warlord, who, for a share of the crops they harvested from his lands, he swore to protect. These warlords became knights, barons and princes, and all swore allegiance officially to the Emperor, but in practice served their liege, or local king. In the large towns and cities, opportunistic men who saw profit in the regulation of the limited resources of the times became known as burghers. The nobility and the merchants gained a level of power they had not held previous to the First Inquisition, and they were about to take one step back and two forward.

There is no doubt that Baudri was the most blood thirsty Scion to ever rule in the Valdenwail. It was rumoured that he personally stalked the lands as the “**Inquisitor Beodreath**”, and tales of this man still

scare children and adults alike to this day. Whether this historic figure, inflated as he likely is, was actually Baudri or not is a matter for academic debate in ale houses, and not the class room. What is uncontested is that Baudri backed the bloodier of the two Inquisitions, the Second. His Inquisitors were even more ruthless than those of Nicetus and Tancred. How such policies and practices could come from the Son of Mailous is another matter for less structured academic debate, but is puzzling all the same. Beodreath was known to erect forests of corpses on pikes, and though the First Inquisition was ended when a single village was obliterated, Inquisitors of the Second left dozens of such scars on the Empire.

One must not forget that the Caspaarians were doing the same to the empire at the same time, though to a lesser degree. There were many Caspaarians put to the pike by Inquisitors of this age, but there are many records surviving that terrible time of Inquisitors conscripting the already-seasoned butcherous mobs of the Caspaarians into their retinues. It was a terrifying time for anyone in Avilund in that age; the people were struggling not only with the triple internal threat of Caspaarians, Inquisitors and Black Faith (though the smarter Black Faithful no doubt kept a low profile in this age), but the Kells again returned to harass the Northern Provinces, and a number of Feral warlords had grown powerful enough to march into the Bishoprics of St. Sebald (Lysander) and St. Ignatius. Therefore, the True Faithful of the Learned Saint, and the much-needed Crusading Orders had more trouble than they could handle, and could not provide a military check to the slaughter of the time.

Though body counts are always a dodgy matter in any conflict, this one is even more difficult to put a number to. There were just too few records left, and too few people willing to account for what they had seen, lest they become the next corpse on a pike. However, many scholars have since devoted their entire academic careers to assessing the damage of this ungovernable era, and there is a general agreement in the Community that it was doubtless not less than 3 million killed, possibly double that. The number would represent about 1 citizen in 8, or possibly 1 in 4, finding their death at the hands of the Caspaarians and the the Inquisitors. A terrible number, to be sure.

The end of the Second Inquisition was not to come from the North this time. The Northerners had more than enough trouble than they could handle with the Kells, and indeed offered but token nobles to the Revolution that was about to happen. It was in the City of St. Avitus (Waldheim) in 1346 that change took hold. A council of nobles calling themselves the **Order of Bellweather** formed, in response to the fires and corpses choking the streets of their Province and City. Through much plotting and the complete elimination of Saintry leadership in their Order, they managed to put together a small army of some 3000 men, who, on Oct 1, 1346, rounded up the senior clergy of every major and minor Canon in the City, and had them gently imprisoned in the Blue Palace. The Order appeared on the Emperors Balcony, 5 hooded men who clearly wore the gowns and trappings of nobility, and declared the City independent of the Rule of the PDF and the Scion. They declared that the Clergy would no longer have any political authority in the City, and that until the bloodshed of the Inquisition ceased, all senior clergy would remain imprisoned. They also changed the name of the City to Waldheim, which it remains today.

The elicited the response one would expect from the Scion; Baudri was a hot head and a blood thirsty maniac, and sent word to every Inquisitor stalking the Empire that they were to attack the City at once, and put the Order of Bellweather to the pike or the fire as soon as possible. The Inquisitors of the Second Inquisition were man terrible and able things; they were able to turn sons against mothers, and invoke fear in the hearts of all who saw them, but they were no military force. From November that year, until the Spring of 1347, the Inquisitors arrived piecemeal to confront the Order, and all were met with an organized and growing Republican Army, which was able to repel them, and capture and imprison many Inquisitors.

Baudri eventually called off his Inquisitors, and called a general retreat and regrouping; his Inquisitors and their retinues returned to the Valdenwail and to Dimmantle, where they awaited word from their Scion. The Order and the Republican Army played a very strategic card at that point; the army had grown to over 10,000 men, many of which were now seasoned and confident. They sent two regiments to assist the Bishopric of St. Ignatius in their struggle against the **MacGawnowich Ferrals** in June of 1347, and by the end of August, the Bishopric was liberated from their struggle. This move helped to ingratiate the newly-founded Order and the Republican Army with the staunch supporters of the PDF, and resulted in more support and more troops.

In the south, the **Dungorgon Ferral Horde** which had been pressing back the Crusading Order armies of Lysander retreated, no doubt suspecting that the human armies would unite to bring the ferrals between them for a crushing victory. If their generals knew of the animosity between the Crusading Orders, which still mostly supported the Scion, and the Republican Army, they would likely have stayed, and the world would be a different place. However, they did not.

Unfortunately, the strict dogma by which the Crusading Orders lived their lives was more than enough to make them blind to the madness of Baudri, and as the Dungorgons retreated, they regrouped and planned to march upon St. Ignatius and Waldheim. Emisaries from both the Order and the Ignatians were sent to make peace with Lysander and her Knights, but this could not be achieved, and so a long year of internecine fighting took hold. It must have been a pitiful thing, to see the Republican Army and the Crusading Orders fighting over villages which had become nothing more than empty graveyards after the passing of the Inquisitors and Caspaarians who had brought about this struggle. All was not mindless conflict though; the Pilgrims of Vander refused to take the field against any army which bore the standards of any Saintly Canon, and it was not long before every Republican Army found itself aided by a spiritual advisor, usually an Ignatian. However, the Ordo Croceus Cervis followed the orders of the Scion without a thought, and many unfortunate battles across the Imperial South and the in the Imperial Septum could not be avoided.

The Crusaders were able to muster strength as they marched across the South, towards the Valdenwail, just as the Republic was able to do so as it marched through the Nith Valley, until it crossed the Antiquitus Via. At this point, the Republican forces were split into four; the Northern Army, which marched to assist the Northern Provinces with their struggles against the Kells, the Ignatian Relief Army, which had helped in the war against the MacGawnowiches, and now fought against the OCC in the Bishopric of St. Ignatius, the Waldheim Army, which held the City against any threat, and the Expeditionary Army, which marched over the Septum and into the Imperial South with the aim of setting siege to the Valdenwail.

It is the actions of the Expeditionary Army which historians of the **Novae Res Sanguinius** are chiefly concerned with. On August 17, 1347, this division of 7000 men and 1000 heavy horse crossed the Septum with little resistance, but found a large garrison in St. Mairin's Gate at the base of the mountains. The pass down to the Gate gave the Republican Army the benefit of high ground, but they had no siege engines, nor did they wish to use such indiscriminate weapons for their cause. Further, though it was lower down in the mountains, the Gate was and is situated on a great bluff which commands the plain beneath it, and it has only a small and vulnerable mountain road leading to it which would cost the Republic dearly to use. **General Woefall Ulmar**, the leader of the Expeditionary Army decided to make a forced march past the Gate, enduring the artillery which the Crusaders no doubt had entrenched in the Gate. It cost them dearly to pass; over 2000 men and 400 horse were killed in the mad rush down the pass and onto the plain. The artillery continued to harass the Expeditionary Army until it was out of range. At that point, **General-Brother Moldan Grist** rode out with his Crusader-Brothers and the men-at-arms they had conscripted along the way. They numbered some 4000, 700 of which were Crusaders, and fighters of the finest sort.

On the olive plains below St. Mairin's Gate, the two armies positioned themselves, across a small valley. A tent was erected, and the Generals and their staffs met to discuss terms and Rules of Combat. However, Ulmar had a dirty trick up his sleeve. During the negotiations, alarms sounded up in the Gate as a portion of the Waldheim Army which had marched in secret a day behind the main Expeditionary Army charged down the slopes and overran the Gate. This small detachment of about 1500 men now commanded the Gate and its artillery, which the main force of Grist's army was now at the mercy of. The discussion between the two Generals in the tent is a thing of well-recorded legend. There are poetic and lengthy accounts of it in several documents, but the summary of it was this; that Ulmar smiled as he saw the furrowed brow of his opponent harden at the realization of what was happening up in the Gate. Grist had guessed what had happened without having to get word from outside the tent, and though he grew angry, he smiled. Ulmar is known to have said the following;

"I am loathe to turn your instruments of war against you or any other Goode Man of Avilund. I have sacrificed many pawns to get you onto this Honourable Field, and now you see the Queen ahead of you,

prostrate and vulnerable, for I know that my new Army could not master the discipline that the Pilgrims of Vander possess. You may strike at the queen, but you will leave the King vulnerable; you will be destroyed by your own artillery. Please good and Honourable Knight, please acquiesce!"

Grist is known to have said the following.

"You misguess your role, General. We are all but pawns." And he departed the tent. Ulmar is known to have blanched.

The Battle of Olive Plain commenced less than an hour after the tent was struck. It is sometimes called the Battle of Tears, for both sides could see the faces of their adversaries across the valley, and knew them for countrymen and kin, and many wept that they should cross blades. However, the discipline of General Grist was absolute, and though the trebuchet and cannon were poised on the bluff above to cripple his army with a single wave of a black flag in the ranks of his opponents on the other side of the valley, he knew his duty, and he charged. The report from the cannons above was terrible; it was the first time Men of Avilund fired the new and terrible weapons at each other, and it was terrifying for both sides. The conscripted men-at-arms of the Crusader force broke quickly under the terror of those guns, but the Pilgrims of Vander themselves charged out, and though they were but a tithe the strength of the Expeditionary Army, they killed and routed over half of it, and General Ulmar himself was cut down in the battle. In the end, the Pilgrims all lay dead, having fought to a man upon a heap of their Brothers.

After this battle, the Expeditionary Army halted at the Gate, and held the pass all the rest of that year, awaiting reinforcements. With the Pilgrims of Vander all but destroyed, and the Ordo Croceus Cervus locked in siege with the Ignatian army in that Bishopric, the Imperial South lay open to the Republican Army. However, it did not advance until the following spring when a portion of the Northern army returned from their wars in the north with the Kells. They were reduced in number to about 3500, but that was enough to bring the spirits of the wintered Expeditionary Army to a fighting level. This force now numbered over 8000, many of them veterans. However, word soon reached them from the Ignatians that the OCC had lifted siege, and was making its way as quickly as possible to the defense of the Valdenwail. The OCC would have to cross the Septum and travel over 600 miles to make the Valdenwail. The Expeditionary Army was but 350 miles from the Valdenwail, and thus things looked good for the Republic.

However, the Expeditionary Army would not get to the Valdenwail before some troops arrived to reinforce it. Though different historical accounts must be examined to piece together what happened next, it is now a thing of legend-cum-fact that 300 of the most senior Brothers of the Golden Stag departed in great haste from the main of the OCC force. They were never seen by their brethren again. In July, when the van of the EA approached the Hedge, they were met with 300 heavy horse who all wore ancient armour from the early days of the *Saeculum Maximus Congregius*. With them was a small retinue of emissaries from the Valdenwail. The van never made the approach across the valley before the Hedge. They lost there nerve, each and every man, and turned back.

A week later, when the main force approached the valley before the Hedge, they found the same 300 mounted men in their ancient armour and the retinue awaiting talks. There was one masked member of the Order of Bellweather leading the Army, and he had several experienced Captains and two Generals with him, but none of them could find the courage to cross the valley under the terrible glare of those 300 sentinels. The Scion's retinue rode out ahead of their ominous guard, and awaited a council from the newly founded Republic, but after a few hours, when it did not cross the valley, there was heard a great cackling in the valley, and the retinue and 2/3 of the sentinels departed, heading back into the Hedge.

At this point there was much desertion. The Captains ordered a siege be set, but more than half of their men left that very night, and in the morning, not a single siege machine had been erected. Parties were sent to round up deserters, and messages sent to Waldheim requesting more help and advice. The awkward cycles of desertion and round-up, attrition and re-supply continued for two more months, until the cool Autumn fell upon the haphazard siege. Unfortunately, at this point the main force of the OCC arrived on the right flank of the siege, and another great battle was to be fought. Brother-General Maxamillian Grudge, the leader of the OCC wasted not a moment in deliberations. As he arrived on the field on

September 28, 1348, his men positioned for battle immediately. The EA tried to make the preparations required to meet them, but the will of that camp was still unsettled, and they made a terrible resistance for so large a force. Though they numbered about 10,000 at that point, the OCC was only 2500, counting some 240 Crusaders among them. This battle, The Battle of Hedgefield, was a terrible and chaotic affair that the Crusaders were well suited to. Every one of the Crusaders and the men-at-arms of the OCC fought to the death, at when the dust settled, there were only 1900 men of the EA left standing, with no Captains or Generals among them. The only leader left alive was the masked Bellweather, and he was ready to call a retreat. News had come that the Crusading Orders in Lysander were mounting a second wave, and though it would be markedly more anemic than the two forces the EA had already faced, they knew that the men could not bear to meet with such enthusiastic opponents again. Add to this their unwillingness to march a single step towards the ominous hedge and its handful of awe-inspiring guardians, and it seemed that the 'siege' of the Valdenwail had come to an end. They made preparations to strike the camp. The next day brought better news, though; the Ignatian Army, which had been on the heels of the OCC, was nearing, and a great host was coming down from the City to reinforce. This was barely enough to keep the tattered remains of the EA in place, but it did.

By October, the two forces did arrive nearly simultaneously from the West and the North. The EA was surprised to see the Ignatian Army in such good shape; they had to cross 600 miles of the Imperial South, which had never loosened its allegiance to the Scion in any province, and it was still a populous region. However, the Ignatian host arrived unscathed with a full complement of 8000 troops, and the Waldheim Regiment with another 4000. As they arrived, the full complement of 300 sentinels again rode out to face them from across the valley, and again, it had the intended effect on most of the men. However, the Ignatians did not falter. While thousands of men around them lost their nerve and broke, the Ignatian Host remained as an island of resolute will. It was at this time that they unveiled the great Palanquin which bore the body of St. Ignatius inside a gilded glass box, suspended some 60' in the air. The banners of the Ignatians were all waved in rally and defiance, and the grim sentinels on the opposite side of the valley shuffled a bit. The unveiling of the shriveled and grisly Artifact rallied the rest of the Armies, and they stood as a single unified host of almost 14,000 across from the Hedge. Though they had been rallied, they would not charge against those 300 sentinels, though. So it was that siege was again set, and this time, the engines from St. Mairins gate were brought to the line to threaten the Hedge.

On October 30, 1348, the emissaries of the Scion again rode out from the Hedge, and this time, they rode to the nape of the valley under flags of truce to meet with the generals of the Republican Army. This time, emissaries from the RA did in fact ride down to meet them. They had many generals, 3 masked Bellweathers, and many bishops among them, including **Prelate Scaerwyn of St. Ignatius**. There are very few accounts of what transpired at this meeting; those from the Republic that were there never revealed nor recorded any of the proceedings. It is known that a tent was struck up, and after several hours, most of the Republic retinue was dismissed, except for one Bellweather and the Prelate of St. Ignatius. Several hours later, they again returned to the tent bearing a great chest, which some thought would be a bribe of some unfathomably valuable treasure. The tent was struck down shortly after that, and both retinues rode up the hill towards the Hedge, and past the parting Sentinels. Presumably, they met with the Scion himself somewhere inside the Hedge in some secret and forgotten building, and a day later they emerged. Prelate Scaerwyn addressed the Army on the morning of October 31 as the sun was rising. His speech is well documented in a number of accounts, and sounded much like this;

Good and Sainly Men of Avilund, I present to you (as he held aloft a great parchment) the Placitum a Terminus Potentia, signed by Emperor Baudri himself last night at the stroke of midnight. This document releases the people of Avilund from the Rule of the Emperor. The Empire is no longer! The Tyranny of the Inquisition and the evil of Men in Avilund has come to an end. Peace has replaced murder, prosperity has replaced famine. All Men are now Free to choose their Leaders and their Laws as they see fit. I know that we will all choose Goode and Sainly men to lead us, and we will be free of the Absolutism of an Emperor. The Scion is now Emperor of the small Ecclesiarchy on the other side of that Hedge alone. And though he and his descendants will always hold their sacred position as Scion and Spiritual Figurehead of our Sainly Faith, he and his will no longer rule our lives from within his obscure walls. Peace and Independence have come to Avilund! Return to your homes and govern yourselves in Goode and Sainly fashion! But never forget that Peace was won at a terrible price.

The Placitum itself and the long-term effects of the word-of-the-law printed upon it are matters for more in-depth studies of the Novae Res Sanguinius. However, Scaerwyn did in fact bear that document to the people on that morning, and the Empire did come to an end that very morning, and the Modern World was born. But, it was won at a terrible price, as the Prelate had mentioned. It was not long before it was discovered that the remains of the body of St. Ignatius had been removed from its glass tomb on the Palanquin, and that the terrible price that Scaerwyn was talking about was not only the cost of blood and the lasting pangs of the battles of Men against Men, but also the Holy Artifact of his Canon. The body of St Ignatius found its way, no doubt, to the Magnus Collego Sanctus that very day.

Modern History

New Rules

Languages

The rules found in the PHB for languages need some expanding. This is detailed herein.

There are 4 major *languages* in this setting, and each has a number of *dialects*. Most characters will start off with New Imperial as their native language, and will choose one dialect from the regional dialect list below. It is possible to understand someone who speaks the same language, though a different dialect, but this requires a *dialect check*.

Learning a new language is a little different from the rules in the PHB. Characters will have varying levels of competency in a given language which is determined by how many ranks they take in a given language. This is much like the skill system, except that there are fewer checks with languages, and thus, the rules are a little different. A character's proficiency in a given language is based on how many ranks in that language he has. The table below shows what level of competency that character has in a given language;

1 Rank: Can understand the language and communicate very simple ideas, very slowly. Has a –10 penalty to bluff, diplomacy and performance checks used against those that speak this language.

2 Ranks: Understands the language well and can communicate simple ideas at a regular pace, or complicated ideas slowly. Has a –4 penalty to bluff, diplomacy and performance checks made against those who speak this language)

3 Ranks: Understands and speaks the language very well, and can communicate any thoughts or ideas as fast as in his native tongue. Has a –2 penalty to bluff, diplomacy or performance checks used against those who speak this language.

4 Ranks: Somewhat Literate in the language. Has a –2 penalty to decipher script rolls for this language.

5 Ranks: Mastery of the language; the character can speak the language as if it was his native language (no penalty to bluff or performance checks), and can understand even complicated literature of that language.

Dialects. Each language has several dialects, and every character will have a home-dialect chosen which matches his home region. Ranks of dialects are purchased with skill points exactly as ranks in languages.

1 Rank: The Character can speak and understand the dialect very well and quickly. Has a –2 penalty to Bluff, Diplomacy, Intimidate and Performance.

2 Ranks: The character is perfectly proficient with the language and can pass as a local. No penalties to any relevant skills.

Synergy: A character that has 5 or more ranks in Knowledge: Region for a given region will automatically count as having 1 rank in that region's dialect.

Dialect Check: When two characters attempt to communicate who speak the same language, but different dialects, a *Dialect Check* is required. This is an INT based check with a DC of 10, which each character must pass. The DC is modified by the difficulty of the message that is being conveyed. For example, if they are trying to simply introduce themselves and make their names known to each other, that might be a –2 modifier to the DC. If one is trying to tell the other the formula for a rare and magical potion, the DC modifier might be as high as +20. This check can be attempted 3 times for each message/idea. If it is failed after the third attempt, it is impossible for these two characters to understand each other for that particular missive.

The major languages of the setting include the following;

1. **New Imperial.** This is the main language spoken by most inhabitants of the Empire. There are many different dialects (detailed below), which might make it difficult for some people from some regions to understand people from other regions. New Imperial is simply called “Imperial” by most people that speak it. It is a descendant of Old Imperial with a mixture of Kellish added in.

Dialects: City of Avitus, City of Havilah, City of Lysander, Eastwitch, Kingdom of Mantlethorn, Kingdom of Hiergallad, Republic of Isenwald, Republic of Dunstanmoore, Bishopric of St. Ignatius, Bishopric of St. Mairin, Dominion of St. Lucas, Wellenlund, Gablelund, Patrilund

2. **Old Imperial.** This is the language that was spoken and written mostly before 750. This language is still used by many academics and theological scholars. This language has only a few dialects which are chronological dialects, rather than regional dialects.

Dialects: Early Old Imperial, Middle Old Imperial, Late Old Imperial, Crusader's Old Imperial.

3. **Feral.** This is the language spoken by the Ferals and the Kells. The Kellish dialect of this language is the oldest language spoken by men. There are countless dialects of this language, but it is all rooted in the ancient Kell.

Dialects: There are hundreds of dialects of this tongue. The most common is Kellish, which is spoken by the Kells.

4. **Elderspeech.** This is the language of the Elder Race. There are only a handful of people in the world who can now speak this language, and few more that can read or write it. It is the foundation of most magical writings in the modern day, but even so, most mages know only the bits of this language that pertain to their particular magical studies. This language is pretty much only the domain of committed scholars. This language is not chosen as a regular language (see Feats, below).
5. **Angelic.** This is the language spoken by Angels and some Angelkin. It is also found in many older documents, and some new. This language is quite uncommon, and very difficult to master. As such, it must be purchased with a Feat (see below).
6. **Devilish.** This is the language spoken by the denizens of Hell. It is also spoken by many Devilkin and a few very educated members of the Black Faith. It is found in some old documents, but the Purgation of the 1300's was primarily focused on the destruction of documents with this language. The language is very difficult to master, and as such, it must be purchased with a Feat (see below).
7. **Demonic.** This is the language spoken by the denizens of the Abyss, and many demons that walk the Earth. This language is found in the prolific writings of the many facets of the Black Faith. It is difficult to understand and master, though not as complex as Angelic or Devilish.

Feats

Language: Elderspeech.

Prerequisites: Language: Old Imperial (5 ranks), Kellish (5 ranks), INT 16

Benefits: With this feat, the character is able to take ranks in Language: Elderspeech. This feat does not give any ranks to this skill, and the skill must be purchased as usual. The rules for language above are slightly different for the Elderspeech language. Here is how mastery of this language works;

- 1 Rank; the character is able to decipher only simple Elderspeech writings.
- 2 Ranks: The character is able to decipher Elderspeech writings and runes.
- 3 Ranks: The character is able to decipher all Elderspeech writings, runes and magical writings (if they are normally able to read magical writings).
- 4 Ranks: The character is able to slowly converse in Elderspeech.
- 5 Ranks: The character is able to converse well in Elderspeech.

Language: Angelic

Prerequisites: Religion (Primus Deus Fidelis) (5 ranks), Int 16, Cha 16

Benefits: With this feat, the character is able to take ranks in Language: Angelic. This feat, does not give any ranks to the skill, and the skill must be purchased as usual. The rules for ranks are the same as for those for Language: Elderspeech, above.

Language: Devilish

Prerequisites: Religion (Black Faith) (5 ranks), Int 16, Cha 16.

Benefits: With this feat, the character is able to take ranks in Language: Devilish. This feat, does not give any ranks to the skill, and the skill must be purchased as usual. The rules for ranks are the same as for those for Language: Elderspeech, above.

Language: Demonic

Prerequisites: Religion (Black Faith) (5 ranks), Int 14, Cha 14.

Benefits: With this feat, the character is able to take ranks in Language: Demonic. This feat, does not give any ranks to the skill, and the skill must be purchased as usual. The rules for ranks are the same as for those for Language: Elderspeech, above.

Demon Sight

Prerequisites: None if taken at first level. It may be taken at higher levels if the character has been reduced to 0 hit points or less since choosing his last Feat.

Benefits: The character gains a +20 Aptitude bonus to Spot and Sense Motive checks, for purposes of identifying a Demon in disguise, or trying to hide. This ability also applies to identifying possession. Even invisible or incorporeal demons may be spotted by this character.

Visions

Prerequisites: Must be taken at first level. It may be taken at higher levels if the character has been reduced to 0 hit points or less since choosing his last Feat.

Benefits: The character receives visions in one form or another (dreams, waking hallucinations, signs in clouds, etc.) that are relevant to the adventure or story being played. This feat is passive, and is controlled entirely by the DM. It may give insight into the adventure in any way the DM sees appropriate.

Ghost Sight

Prerequisites: None if taken at first level. It may be taken at higher levels if the character has been reduced to 0 hit points or less since choosing his last Feat.

Benefits: The character gains a +20 Aptitude bonus to Spot and Sense Motive checks for, for purposes of identifying intelligent undead in disguise or trying to hide. This ability also applies to identifying possession. Even invisible or incorporeal undead may be spotted by this character.

Demon Sensitive

Prerequisites: Demon Sight, Wisdom 16+

Benefits: The character is able to sense when demons have passed through an area, are influencing certain events, are somehow watching them. This feat also allows the character to identify people who are likely to be possessed, or who are currently involved in a struggle of some sort with a demon.

Ghost Sensitive

Prerequisites: Ghost Sight, Wisdom 16+

Benefits: The character is able to sense when incorporeal undead have passed through an area, are influencing certain events, are somehow watching them. This feat also allows the character to identify people who are likely to be possessed, or who are currently involved in a struggle of some sort with incorporeal undead.

Skills

Knowledge: Religion (Primus Deus Fidelis)

This skill replaces the standard Knowledge: Religion skill from the PHB. For all intents and purposes, it functions the same, but only for the Primus Deus Fidelis. It does not offer the character any knowledge of the Black Faith.

Knowledge: Religion (Black Faith)

This skill replaces the standard Knowledge: Religion skill from the PHB. For all intents and purposes, it functions the same, but only for the Black Faith. It does not offer the character any knowledge of the Primus Deus Fidelis.

Knowledge: Religion (Nature)

This skill is used for many of the religious rites that are known as ‘Old Magic’. There are many places where people still practice this type of religion. This religion is focused on

the worship of natural forces and astronomy, and is wrongly labeled as “Black Faith” by much of Imperial society.

Profession: Medical Doctor (trained only)

This skill is used to fix seriously wounded and diseased characters. See the optional rules later in this section for wounds, disease and healing. This skill can also be used to earn money as any other professional skill. The Heal skill is still used as usual. This skill is used to treat wounds and ailments that the Heal skill cannot take care of. The Heal skill should be thought of as first aid, or home-remedies that would be found throughout much of the world. The Profession: Medical Doctor skill reflects formal training in the medical arts. This skill has all the benefits of the Heal skill, *except* First Aid treatment.

Synergy: If you have 5 or more ranks in this Profession: Medical Doctor, you get a +2 synergy bonus to Heal checks.

Research.

This skill is used when characters want to dig up information from inanimate sources such as libraries, graveyards and such. A single roll represents a day of research with a given medium in a given location (books, in a library, for example). The DM will have a secret DC that is required for the character to find what he is looking for. The Research skill check is modified by the resources the character has. The DM will modify this roll in secret. Typically, a small library will give a straight roll. A large university library with an assistant helping might confer a +10 bonus to the roll. Note that it might be impossible for the character to dig up the information in the given location, if the information is just not there (the DM only, knows this).

Synergy: +2 for 5 ranks in Decipher Script, +2 for 5 ranks in relevant Knowledge skills.

Character Classes

Academic

This character class is essentially a very skilled, slightly magical character. These are typically archaeologists and other academic-types that have studied a little bit of magic, but are more focused on their skills. Their magic is 'New Magic' or 'Elder Magic' which they have learned through their studies, rather than formal training. They learn, memorize and cast spells as wizards, but they may not specialize.

Alignment: Any

Hit Dice: d6

Class Skills

Appraise, Bluff, Concentration, Craft, Decipher Script, Diplomacy, Disable Device, Disguise, Forgery, Gather Information, Knowledge (any), Listen, Open Lock, Perform, Profession, Research, Search, Sense Motive, Sleight of Hand, Speak Language, Spellcraft, Spot.

Skill Points at 1st Level: (6+ Int modifier) x 4.

Skill Points at Each Additional Level: 6 + Int modifier.

Class Features

All of the following are class features for the Academic.

Weapon and Armour Proficiency: The Academic is proficient with all simple weapons, plus the rapier. They are proficient with all light armour, but not shields.

Spells: The Academic casts arcane spells exactly as a wizard. He learns, prepares and casts exactly like a wizard, but has none of the other benefits of the wizard class (no familiar, no extra metamagic feats).

Spellbooks: The academic uses a spellbook exactly like a wizard. He begins at first level with a spellbook with 4 cantrips, and 3 + Int modifier 1st level spells. The Academic can add spells to this book exactly as a wizard, and furthermore, may add one spell into it for free every level.

Magic Items: Academics can use magic items exactly as mages.

Lifelong Study: A character that takes his first level in Academic has benefits with regards to skills in later levels. Whenever the character takes a level in a class other than Academic, he may still take any of the following skill ranks as class-skills, even if they are not class-skills for the newly chosen character class; Decipher Script, Forgery, Knowledge (any), Research, Speak Language, Spellcraft.

Table 1-1: The Academic

Level	Base	Fort	Ref	Will	Spells/
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	Attack Bonus	Save	Save	Save		Day				
					Cantrips	1st	2nd	3rd	4th	5th
1	+0	+0	+0	+2	1	0	-	-	-	-
2	+1	+0	+0	+3	2	0	-	-	-	-
3	+2	+1	+1	+3	3	1	0	-	-	-
4	+3	+1	+1	+4	4	2	0	-	-	-
5	+3	+1	+1	+4	4	2	1	0	-	-
6	+4	+2	+2	+5	4	3	2	0	-	-
7	+5	+2	+2	+5	4	3	2	1	-	-
8	+6	+2	+2	+6	4	4	3	1	0	-
9	+6	+3	+3	+6	4	4	3	2	0	-
10	+7	+3	+3	+7	4	4	4	2	1	-
11	+8	+3	+3	+7	4	4	4	3	1	0
12	+9	+4	+4	+8	4	4	4	3	2	0
13	+9	+4	+4	+8	4	4	4	4	2	1
14	+10	+4	+4	+9	4	4	4	4	3	1
15	+11	+5	+5	+9	4	4	4	4	3	2
16	+12	+5	+5	+10	4	4	4	4	4	2
17	+12	+5	+5	+10	4	4	4	4	4	3
18	+13	+6	+6	+11	4	4	4	4	4	3
19	+14	+6	+6	+11	4	4	4	4	4	4
20	+15	+6	+6	+12	4	4	4	4	4	4

Professional

This is the player-character class used for such things as merchants, politicians, investigators and the like. This character is also based on the Rogue character class, but with some modifications. There are no Sneak Attack bonuses or any other traditional ‘thief’ abilities. This character class excels at having huge bonuses on their skills, but is a little weak in combat.

Alignment: Any

Hit Dice: d6

Class Skills

All.

Skill Points at First Level: (8 + Int modifier) x 4.

Skill Points each Level: 8 + Int modifier.

Class Features

All of the following are class skills of the Professional.

Weapon and Armour Proficiency: Professionals can use all simple weapons, as well as the rapier. They are proficient with light armour, but not shields.

Saving Throws: The Professional is a character with a great deal of latitude. For this reason, his saving throws are a little unusual. This character chooses which save is his 'strong' save and the other two then become 'weak' saves. Therefore, this character could be resilient like a fighter, quick like a rogue, or strong willed like a wizard.

Professional Focus Skills: At first level, this character chooses three Professional Focus Skills. These can be any three skills. The character may always take ranks in these skills as class-skills, even when taking a level in a class that may not choose these skills as class-skills. Furthermore, the character gets a Professional Competency bonus of +2 to each of those three skills.

At levels 5, 10 and 15, the professional chooses another skill to make a Professional Focus Skill. The +2 Professional Competency Bonus is added right away, but any ½ ranks that were chosen in this skill previously are not upgraded to full ranks. The skill does become a class-skill for every class for this character from this time on, however.

Skill Mastery: At levels 3, 6, and 9, the Professional may select one of its Professional Focus Skills to master. The Professional may always take 10 in this skill, regardless of situation.

Bonus Feats: At levels 1, 2, 4, 7, 8, 11, 14, 16, 17, 19, and 20, the Professional may take a bonus feat. The bonus feat may be chosen from the following list; Acrobatic, Agile, Alertness, Animal Affinity, Athletic, Deceitful, Deft Hands, Diligent, Great Fortitude, Investigator, Iron Will, Leadership, Lightning Reflexes, Magical Aptitude, Negotiator, Nimble Fingers, Persuasive, Run, Skill Focus, Stealthy, Toughness, and Track.

Table 1-2: The Professional

Level	Base Attack Bonus	Weak Save	Weak Save	Strong Save	Special
1	+0	+0	+0	+2	Professional Focus Skills, Bonus Feat
2	+1	+0	+0	+3	Bonus Feat
3	+2	+1	+1	+3	Skill Mastery

4	+3	+1	+1	+4	Bonus Feat
5	+3	+1	+1	+4	New Focus
6	+4	+2	+2	+5	Skill Mastery
7	+5	+2	+2	+5	Bonus Feat
8	+6	+2	+2	+6	Bonus Feat
9	+6	+3	+3	+6	Skill Mastery
10	+7	+3	+3	+7	New Focus
11	+8	+3	+3	+7	Bonus Feat
12	+9	+4	+4	+8	
13	+9	+4	+4	+8	New Focus
14	+10	+4	+4	+9	Bonus Feat
15	+11	+5	+5	+9	
16	+12	+5	+5	+10	Bonus Feat
17	+12	+5	+5	+10	Bonus Feat
18	+13	+6	+6	+11	
19	+14	+6	+6	+11	Bonus Feat
20	+15	+6	+6	+12	Bonus Feat

Optional Rules: Wounds, Infection, Diseases and Healing.

The world is a dangerous place, and even moreso for the adventurous. The rules below reflect some of the inherent dangers of getting injured. These rules are optional, and will be used at the discretion of the DM.

Wound Types

There are two types of wounds; Regular and Critical. Regular wounds are those inflicted over the course of combat. Critical wounds are inflicted when critical hits are scored, or a character's HP's drop below 0. If these optional rules are followed, each player will be required to keep track of the number of each type of wound he receives.

Regular Wounds: A character that takes a number of regular wounds has a chance of generating an infection. This chance is known only by the DM, and is based upon the types of weapons inflicting the wounds, and the environment in which the wounds are sustained. After an encounter, a single Fort Save is made for the regular wounds the character has sustained. For every 3 regular wounds, the DC goes up by +1. A typical scenario (a character injured by a longsword of no particular state of cleanliness, in a setting of no particular state of cleanliness or filthiness) would have to make a Fort save DC 10. Only the DM knows what the DC is, though, and he may make the roll in secret.

Critical Wounds: When a character takes a critical hit, the DM will determine what additional effect, beyond the regular damage, that the wound has. This will typically be a point of ability damage, or a seriously bleeding wound (loosing 1 hp/round until treated). The wounds also have a chance of causing infection, as with regular wounds, but each wound is rolled for, and the DC's are typically 5 higher.

Recovery from Regular Wounds: A character recovers from regular wounds as per the rules in the PHB. This can be accelerated by use of the Heal Skill, or the Profession: Medical Doctor Skill.

Recovery from Critical Wounds: A character does not recover from critical wounds as usual. Before the character can naturally heal any damage from a critical

wound, a Fort Save must be made. The DC of the Fort save will typically be $10 + \frac{1}{2}$ the damage inflicted by the wound (though the DM will know the actual DC). If the wound caused ability damage, a Fort save must be made for this damage as well, with the same DC. The Profession: Medical Doctor skill can be used to treat these injuries, just as regular damage is treated by the Heal skill. The Heal skill cannot be used to treat these injuries, though it can be used to stop immediate bleeding and HP loss.

Infection: When a character has an infected wound, he will suffer some ability point damage (temporary) while the infection persists. All infections from wounds have an incubation time of 1 day, and a Fort save must be made every subsequent day to avoid further ability point damage. If two Fort saves are passed two days in a row, the infection is defeated, and the character will begin to recover ability point damage as normal on the third day. Infection can also be treated by the Heal and Profession: Medical Doctor skills. A character can have many infections, and in fact, numerous critical hits may lead to numerous infections. Critical hits that cause ability point damage will cause the same ability to become damaged on subsequent days through infection. While a character makes Fort saves for each infection that he has, only a limited number of Heal or Profession: Medical Doctor checks can be made. Characters using those skills may treat as many infections in one patient as their Wisdom bonus (Heal) or Intelligence bonus (Profession: Medical Doctor).

